

JOURNAL OF AFRICAN CHRISTIAN BIOGRAPHY

Vol. 11, No. 2-3 (Apr-July 2026)

Focus: Catholics and Women in
Nigeria



A publication of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography*

JOURNAL OF AFRICAN CHRISTIAN BIOGRAPHY

Vol. 11, No. 2-3 (Apr-July 2026)

A quarterly publication of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography* (www.DACB.org)



The JACB is an open access publication of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography* and the Center for Global Christianity and Mission at Boston University School of Theology



CONOVER-PORTER
AWARD



NATIONAL ENDOWMENT FOR THE
humanities



BEST SITES
AWARD 2009

JOURNAL OF AFRICAN CHRISTIAN BIOGRAPHY

The *Journal of African Christian Biography* (JACB) publishes research on biographies of African Christians. The primary focus is on the role of local agents in the spread of Christianity in Africa. The JACB is an open access publication committed to facilitating global conversations among scholars across cultures, nations, Christian traditions, and academic specializations, with particular emphasis on Africa. We invite contributions from individuals affiliated with religious and educational institutions in Africa and elsewhere.

CONTENT includes:

- Original biographies and African Christian histories
- Biographies highlighted from the DACB website
- Obituaries and tributes about recently deceased figures
- Excerpts of recently published scholarship
- Interviews with select African church leaders and scholars (still living)
- Resources for teaching with biography
- Reviews of scholarship on African Christian biography and history

SUBMISSIONS: Please direct all inquiries regarding submissions and advertising to the editor at dacb@bu.edu. Refer to the *Instructional Manual for Writers* for guidelines and formatting: https://dacb.org/resources/final_instr_manual.pdf.

FREE SUBSCRIPTIONS: Sign up at www.dacb.org/journal/

ADDRESS: The office of the *Journal of African Christian Biography* is located at the Center for Global Christianity and Mission

Boston University School of Theology
745 Commonwealth Avenue,
Boston, MA 02215, U.S.A.

ISSN 2572-0651

The JACB is an open-access publication of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography* (DACB.org) and the Center for Global Christianity and Mission at Boston University School of Theology. JACB is indexed at the ATLA Religion Database, Open BU, and <https://DACB.org/journal/>. The JACB is licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial International 4.0 License (CC BY-NC 4.0)



DONATE

The open access pdf of this journal is distributed under the following conditions: The pdf may not be sold or used for profit.. The pdf may be printed only for private or institutional use, not for profit.



JOURNAL OF AFRICAN CHRISTIAN BIOGRAPHY

Established in 2016

Quarterly publication of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography*

Editor

Michèle Sigg
Boston University

Assistant Editor

Stephen Kariuki Apollo Warui
Boston University

Associate Editors

Dana Robert
Boston University
Nimi Wariboko
Boston University

Book Notes Editor

Frances (Beth) Restrick
Boston University

Consulting Editor

Jonathan Bonk
Boston University

Editorial Board

Esther Acolatse
Garrett-Evangelical Theological Seminary
Tekletsadik Belachew
Concordia Seminary
Jean-Luc Enyegue
Jesuit Historical Institute in Africa
Casely Essamuah
Global Christian Forum
Anicka Fast
Mennonite Mission Network
Mary Getui
Catholic University of Eastern Africa
Stan Chu Ilo
De Paul University
Fohle Lygunda
Africa Center for Interdisciplinary Studies

Kehinde Olabimtan

St. Stephen's College, University of Alberta
Kyama Mugambi
Yale University

Contributing Editors

James N. Amanze
University of Botswana
Deji Isaac Ayegboyin
University of Ibadan
Jesse Mugambi
University of Nairobi
Philomena Njeri Mwaura
Kenyatta University
Paul Nchoji Nkwi
Catholic University of Cameroon
Olusegun Obasanjo
National Open University of Nigeria
Thomas Oduro
Good News Theological College and Seminary

[page left blank]

Contents

Introduction: Christ's Servants in the Catholic Church of Nigeria by Michele Sigg, Editor.....	1
Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga (1928–2005): Biafran Humanitarianism and the Indigenization of the Catholic Church in Nigeria by Edidiong Ekefre	3
Poem: Excerpt from <i>Songs of Childhood: Biafran War Memories</i> by Nimi Wariboko. Abuja, Nigeria: Paperworth Books, 2025.....	17
Introducing: <i>Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Catholic Women in Nigeria, Volume 1</i> edited by Sr. Elizabeth Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA	18
Life of Madam Anna Daboh (1903-1988)	19
Life of Mama Rebecca Hamza (1942–2007).....	23
Life of Mama Elizabeth Ogunlanoh (1922–1986)	30
On Writing the Biographies of African Christian Ancestors: Theology, Memory, and the Power of Story by Fr. Stan Chu Ilo	35
Book Review: <i>Africa Bears Witness: Mission Theology and Praxis in the 21st Century</i> (2024). Edited by Harvey Kwiyani, United Kingdom: Langham Global Library. Reviewed by Stephen Apollo Warui.	622
Recent Print and Digital Resources Related to Christianity in Africa compiled by Beth Restruck.....	65

Photos on cover (top left to bottom, clockwise):

Mama Elizabeth Ogunlanoh, from the collection of Sr. Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA
Archbishop Brian Usanga from the collection of Fr. Edidiong Ekefre
Mama Rebecca Hamza, from the collection of Sr. Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA

Adire cloth graphic, with permission from [Adire African Textiles](#)

Please join our work by becoming a

Friend of DACB

The Friends of DACB is a community of individuals invested in the work of mission, global networks, scholarship, theological education, and shalom in the church in Africa. The Friends of DACB support the work of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography* Project by assisting with:

- Promotion: Publicizing the mission of the DACB, and recruiting writers, instructors, and institutions to contribute content.
- Financial sustainability: Providing a core amount of money to sustain the project and help it to grow into the future.
- Networking: Helping to find collaborators in academia, web development, publishing houses, church leadership, mission agencies, educational institutions.
- Prayer for all those involved in this work

We invite you to become part of the mission of the DACB and the *Journal of African Christian Biography*. We need a global community of friends to build a sustainable and innovative future for this work.



For more information or to get involved, contact:

Mrs. Judy Stebbins, Chair

Email: jcistebbins@gmail.com OR

Dr. Michele Sigg

Email : dacb@bu.edu ; dacbfriends@gmail.com

DONATE

Introduction: Christ's Servants in the Catholic Church of Nigeria

By Michele Sigg, Editor

The Catholic Church is the largest Christian tradition (single denomination) in Africa with 17.5% of the continent's population. Catholicism is, however, more prevalent in regions that were historically occupied by French or Portuguese colonial powers. In Nigeria, a former British colony, Catholics make up 12.4% of the population alongside Protestants (all denominations) and the Pentecostal-Charismatic movement that each represent 30% of Nigerian Christians.¹

In Nigeria, the majority of the Catholic population is concentrated in eight dioceses in the eastern part of the country. During the 1967-1970 civil war, the Nigerian Catholic Church suffered tremendously due to loss of life and displacement because the war raged for three years primarily in the eastern region.² This issue's leading biography features Fr. Dr. Brian Davis Usanga (1928-2005) who served as part of the humanitarian efforts of the Catholic Church during the war. Then, as archbishop, he spent the next twenty years rebuilding the church in that region.³

The second half of our issue showcases three biographies of lay women from the recently published book *Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Catholic Women in Nigeria, Volume 1*, edited by Sr. Elizabeth Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA. This volume was published in Nigeria in partnership with the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography* and the Pan-African Catholic Theology and Pastoral Network, in association with Anchor Book Publisher Africa (The Pan African Pen Ambassadors, www.abpublisherfrica.com). This book is the first of a multi-volume, multi-year, multi-country project to document the stories of African Catholic lay women. The first year, research projects were hosted in Nigeria, Cameroon, Kenya, and Uganda. In his introduction to the volume, Director of PACTPAN (Pan-African Catholic Theological and Pastoral Network, <https://pactpan.org/>) Fr. Stan Chu Ilo, PhD, a member of the DACB International Editorial Board, underlines the importance of the DACB as "a source of African missional theology" because, in part, it is "an African ancestral project."⁴ Ilo goes on to explain what he means by this:

The DACB is an act of the new apostles of the Lord, transmitting the mighty works of God in Africa and from Africa to the rest of the world through the

¹ *World Christian Encyclopedia*, edited by Todd M. Johnson and Gina A. Zurlo (Edinburgh, Scotland: Edinburgh University Press Ltd, 2020), 8, 589.

² *World Christian Encyclopedia*, 590.

³ *World Christian Encyclopedia*, 590.

⁴ Stan Chu Ilo, "On Writing the Biographies of African Christian Ancestors: Theology, Memory, and the Power of Story," *Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Women of Nigeria, Volume 1* (AfriCap, 2025), 23

biographies of African witnesses to the faith. These stories reveal God's footprints in African history. They also challenge us to model ourselves after the examples of these African Christians and to work hard in our own times, using the resources available to us, to build on what they have done and to draw inspiration from the Holy Spirit. The DACB opens new roads to writing African Christian history. The essential point is communication through narration of the love of God and God's mighty deeds in Africa.⁵

In its concluding pages, the issue offers a review by assistant editor Stephen Apollo Warui of *Africa Bears Witness: Mission Theology and Praxis in the 21st Century* (2024), a collection of articles edited by Harvey Kwiyan, and, of course, our Book Notes of useful resources and recent work, compiled by Beth Restrict, Head of Boston University African Studies library and member of the DACB Executive Committee.

At a time in history when our suffering world is crying out for trustworthy models of integrity and courage to confront the forces of darkness, may these few figures of faithful service, a clergyman from a position of power and lay women in the local context of church communities, offer us hope and insight for our own journey ahead.

⁵ Stan Chu Ilo, "On Writing the Biographies of African Christian Ancestors," 25.

Archbishop Brian, Davis Usanga (1928–2005): Biafran Humanitarianism and the Indigenization of the Catholic Church in Nigeria

By Edidiong Ekefre



Brian Davis Usanga (1928–2005) was the first indigenous bishop and later archbishop of Calabar. Usanga's significance lies in his role as a pioneering indigenous church leader whose episcopate intersected with three defining historical developments: the indigenization of Catholic leadership following colonial rule, the Church's humanitarian response during the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970), and the postwar reconstruction and expansion of Catholic institutions in southeastern Nigeria. Usanga combined pastoral leadership with humanitarian diplomacy, educational development, and institutional building. He served as

Secretary-General of the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria during the Civil War, collaborated with national and international Catholic relief networks, and committed to rebuilding schools, healthcare facilities, and ecclesiastical structures in the aftermath of the conflict. Usanga played a decisive role in transforming the Catholic Church from a missionary-founded institution into an indigenous ecclesial community. His legacy extends beyond the Archdiocese of Calabar and constitutes an important chapter in the history of African Christianity.

Introduction

The history of the Catholic Church in southeastern Nigeria is inseparable from the emergence of indigenous ecclesiastical leadership during the twentieth century. While the pioneering work of Irish missionaries laid the institutional foundations of Catholicism in the region, the consolidation and expansion of the Church increasingly depended upon Nigerian clergy who assumed pastoral, administrative, and intellectual leadership during the closing decades of colonial rule and the formative years of Nigeria's independence. Among these indigenous church leaders, Brian Davis Usanga occupies a distinctive place. As the first indigenous Bishop of Calabar and later the first Archbishop of the Metropolitan See of Calabar, Usanga provided leadership during one of the most turbulent periods in Nigerian history. His episcopacy coincided with political independence, the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970), postwar reconstruction, ecclesiastical indigenization, and the rapid expansion of Catholic institutions across southeastern Nigeria.

As Secretary-General of the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria during the Civil War,

he participated in diplomatic initiatives aimed at preventing armed conflict, coordinated ecclesiastical responses to one of Africa's worst humanitarian disasters, and helped rebuild Catholic educational and healthcare institutions devastated by the war. His episcopal leadership also accelerated the localization of church governance by promoting indigenous clergy, establishing seminaries and schools, encouraging religious vocations, and strengthening Catholic participation in national development. Usanga's enduring legacy lies not only in the offices he held but also in his successful integration of pastoral leadership, educational advancement, humanitarian service, and institution-building during a critical period in Nigerian history.

Historical Background: The Catholic Church in Calabar and the Rise of Indigenous Leadership

The emergence of Usanga as the first indigenous Bishop of Calabar cannot be understood apart from the wider development of Catholicism in southeastern Nigeria. Catholic missionary activity in the region expanded during the early twentieth century under the leadership of the Society of African Missions and, from 1930, the newly established St. Patrick's Missionary Society (Kiltegan Fathers). Their work transformed the Vicariate of Calabar through evangelisation, education, healthcare, and the establishment of enduring ecclesiastical institutions.⁶ Among the most influential missionaries was Bishop James Moynagh, who volunteered for service in southern Nigeria in 1930 under the St. Patrick's Missionary Society.⁷

Moynagh's greatest historical contribution, however, was perhaps his unwavering commitment to developing indigenous leadership. At a time when many mission territories remained overwhelmingly dependent upon expatriate clergy, he actively encouraged the education and formation of Nigerian priests and viewed local leadership as indispensable to the future of the Church.⁸ His educational policy emphasized broad access rather than sectarian exclusivity. Institutions such as Holy Family College, Abak, and St. Patrick's College, Calabar, admitted students from diverse denominational and ethnic backgrounds, creating opportunities for academically gifted young Nigerians who might otherwise never have encountered Catholic education.⁹ One of those beneficiaries was Usanga.

Although raised outside the Catholic tradition, Usanga's admission to Holy Family College brought him into sustained contact with Catholic intellectual life,

⁶ Colman Cooke, *Bishop James Moynagh of Calabar*, Dublin, The Columba Press: 2014. & Thomas Kiggins, *Maynooth Mission to Africa: The Story of St Patrick's Kiltegan*: Dublin, Gill & Macmillan: 1991.

⁷ Cooke, *Bishop James Moynagh* & Charles Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga: The Shepherd with a Heart of Gold*, Abuja, Paulines, 2021.

⁸ Cosmas Nwosuh, *Cardinal Dominic Ekandem and the Growth of the Catholic Church in Nigeria* (Abuja, Ambassador, 2012), p. 83; "Bishop Moynagh's Recollection" in Christopher McGuiness (ed.), *Souvenir of Silver Jubilee of Episcopal Ordination of His Eminence Cardinal Dominic Ekandem, Bishop of Ikot Ekpene, 1954-1979*, p.11.

⁹ Cooke, *Bishop James Moynagh* & Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*.

spirituality, and missionary leadership. His subsequent conversion to Catholicism, discernment of a priestly vocation, and eventual episcopal career reflected the broader transition of the Nigerian Church from missionary foundations to indigenous stewardship. In this sense, Usanga represented both the culmination of the missionary vision inaugurated by figures such as Bishop Moynagh and the beginning of a new era in which Nigerian clergy increasingly assumed responsibility for directing the growth of the Church. Usanga would become one of the principal architects of this transformation in southeastern Nigeria.

Early Life, Education, and Religious Formation (1928–1946)

Brian Eyo Ekpudem Davis Usanga was born on October 24, 1928, in Oboetim Nsit, in present-day Akwa Ibom State, Nigeria, during the closing decades of British colonial rule. Usanga was born into the family of David Idim Usanga and Princess Isung Etuk Udo Obong.¹⁰ Whereas his grandfather and great-grandfather were reputed traditional herbalists within the local religious culture, his father embraced Christianity. He adopted the name David, symbolizing a transition from indigenous religious traditions to the emerging Christian faith.

According to Charles Etim, his mother experienced an unusually prolonged pregnancy before giving birth unexpectedly while working on her farm under bright sunshine. The infant was consequently named *Eyo*, meaning “sunshine,” to commemorate the circumstances of his birth.¹¹ While such narratives belong primarily to family memory rather than verifiable historical documentation, they illustrate the cultural significance attached to his birth and the retrospective interpretation of his remarkable life. His childhood was, however, marked by both promise and tragedy as he lost his mother at the age of four. Raised for a time under the supervision of his intellectually gifted uncle, Johnson Usanga, the young Usanga quickly acquired a reputation for academic brilliance. His father affectionately nicknamed him “Ninety-Nine” after his uncle, who was celebrated for consistently obtaining exceptionally high examination scores. The nickname soon proved prophetic as the young boy demonstrated unusual intellectual ability throughout his schooling.¹²

Usanga’s formal education began at Three Towns School, Oboetim, before continuing at Ikot Ekan District School and later at Nsit District School, Obot Idim Nsit.¹³ His exceptional academic performance distinguished him from his peers. He advanced rapidly through the primary school system, skipping one of the infant classes, and eventually obtained the First School Leaving Certificate with distinction. Alongside his classroom achievements, he excelled in extracurricular activities, particularly school music and biblical studies, winning distinction in the National Bible Knowledge

¹⁰ “Biography of Most Rev Dr Brian Usanga,” Souvenir Programme of 70th Birthday, 24 October 1998.

¹¹ “Biography of Most Rev Dr Brian Usanga,”

¹² Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.139/140.

¹³ “Biography of Most Rev Dr Brian Usanga,”

Examination. These accomplishments attracted the attention of Protestant missionaries, who increasingly viewed him as a promising candidate for Christian leadership.¹⁴ Before embracing Catholicism, Usanga was closely associated with Protestant missionary communities. Rev. James Westgarth of the Qua Iboe Mission recognised his intellectual promise and employed him as a houseboy, clerk, and trainee evangelist. During this period, Usanga acquired remarkable fluency in Efik, Ibibio, and Annang, enabling him to read Scripture and conduct prayers in several local languages. Such linguistic versatility would later become a significant pastoral asset throughout his episcopal ministry.¹⁵

Usanga's religious affiliations likewise evolved during adolescence. He was baptized into the Qua Iboe Church in 1938 and later joined the Salvation Army in 1939 after becoming attracted to its distinctive style of worship.¹⁶ These experiences broadened his understanding of Christian worship and ministry long before he encountered Catholicism. A decisive turning point occurred in 1941 when he gained admission to Holy Family College, Abak. Originally, he had secured a scholarship to attend the Qua Iboe Institute at Etinan on the recommendation of Rev. C. S. Bennington. Encouraged by his elder brother, however, he instead accepted admission to Holy Family College after impressing the school's principal, Rev. Fr. Hugh Edward Connolly, with his outstanding performance in the entrance examination. The decision proved transformative, exposing him for the first time to Catholic education, liturgy, intellectual tradition, and disciplined spiritual formation.¹⁷

The significance of Holy Family College extended beyond academic instruction. Established under Bishop James Moynagh's educational vision, the institution welcomed students irrespective of denominational affiliation, creating opportunities for talented non-Catholic youths to encounter Catholic scholarship and spirituality. Usanga's enrolment therefore exemplified the conviction that education constituted one of the Church's most effective instruments of evangelisation.¹⁸ Without this inclusive educational policy, it is unlikely that Usanga's subsequent conversion—or indeed his later episcopal leadership—would have occurred.¹⁹ In 1943, after a period of instruction and personal reflection, Usanga was conditionally baptized into the Catholic Church by Rev. Fr. Edward McElligott at Holy Family College.

Usanga's reception into Catholicism represented a carefully considered personal decision rather than the result of institutional coercion, a point consistently emphasized in later accounts of his life. Upon his reception, the Vicar General, Rev. Fr. Peter Duffy, gave him the baptismal name Brian, in honor of his own brother, who had

¹⁴ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.140

¹⁵ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.140-142.

¹⁶ Most Rev. Brian Usanga, "Biographical Data" published in the Souvenir programme of his Episcopal Silver Jubilee Celebration, 1-8 December 1991.

¹⁷ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.143-145.

¹⁸ Cooke, *Bishop James Moynagh*, p.93.

¹⁹ Michael Edem, *Dominic Ignatius Ekandem, 1917-1995: The Prince who became a Cardinal – The Vanguard of Catholicism in Nigeria* (Uyo, Minno Prints: 2016), p.108.

survived military service during the Second World War.²⁰ From the Holy Family College, Usanga proceeded to St. Patrick's College, Calabar, where he finished his secondary education on January 1, 1946. His years of religious exploration, academic excellence, and personal conversion collectively prepared him for the priestly vocation that would soon define his life's work.

Vocation to the Priesthood and Early Pastoral Ministry (1946–1961)

By the time Usanga completed his secondary education at St. Patrick's College in 1946, his conversion to Catholicism had matured into a firm conviction that he was called to the priesthood. His decision, however, was neither immediate nor universally welcomed. Like many first-generation African seminarians whose vocational aspirations challenged prevailing family expectations, Usanga encountered strong opposition from relatives who regarded the Catholic priesthood, with its discipline of celibacy and lifelong commitment to ecclesiastical service, as an uncertain and undesirable career. His elder brother, who had assumed responsibility for his education, was particularly opposed to his decision.²¹

Usanga's application for admission into the seminary was accepted by Bishop James Moynagh whose longstanding commitment to developing indigenous clergy profoundly shaped the future of the Diocese of Calabar. Like other missionary bishops who anticipated the gradual transfer of ecclesiastical leadership to African priests, Moynagh viewed promising young converts such as Usanga as essential to the long-term stability and growth of the local church. Before entering major seminary, Usanga had to pass through a period of probation to test his perseverance, maturity, and pastoral suitability before admitting them to formal philosophical and theological formation. Between 1947 and 1949, he served in several educational and catechetical assignments that introduced him to the practical realities of missionary work among rural communities. His first appointment was at St. Augustine Teachers' Training College, Urua Inyang, where he taught Christian Religious Knowledge, English composition, traditional dance, and other subjects while simultaneously serving as a parish catechist.

Subsequent probationary assignments broadened his pastoral experience. In 1948, he was transferred to St. Alban's Mission, Inen, where he worked under several experienced Irish missionaries, including Fathers Patrick Laffey, Larry Walsh, Tom Grealy, and Robert Mullally. His responsibilities included catechetical instruction, parish administration, and evangelisation among communities where traditional religious practices remained deeply rooted. During this period, he also participated in missionary outreach to individuals associated with the *Ekpe-Ikpa-Ukot*, "Man-Leopard" secret society in the Abak and Opobo divisions, illustrating the continuing encounter between Catholic Christianity and indigenous religious institutions in southeastern

²⁰ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.147–148.

²¹ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.149–151.

Nigeria.²²

Usanga's final probationary posting at St. Joseph's Central Mission, Anua, completed the practical phase of his vocational preparation. Having demonstrated intellectual ability, personal discipline, and pastoral commitment, he was admitted at Bigard Memorial Seminary, Enugu, where he commenced formal ecclesiastical studies in philosophy, Church history, spirituality, and related disciplines.²³ On December 8, 1956, the Feast of the Immaculate Conception, Usanga was ordained to the Catholic priesthood by Bishop James Moynagh at St. Louis Church, Mbiokporo Nsit, his home parish church. Among those participating in the ceremony was Auxiliary Bishop Dominic Ignatius Ekandem, whose friendship with Usanga had begun during their seminary years and would later become one of the most influential ecclesiastical partnerships in Nigerian Catholic history.²⁴

Usanga served as the assistant secretary for Catholic education in the diocese of Calabar in 1957 and as a curate at St. Joseph's Parish, Anua, and later at St. Anne's Parish, Ifuho. He quickly gained a reputation as an energetic missionary and effective preacher. His subsequent appointments as parish priest at St Lawrence, Eman Uruan, and later at St. Mark's Parish, Oron, further demonstrated his willingness to undertake difficult missionary assignments among communities where traditional religious institutions remained influential. His evangelization relied less on confrontation than on sustained catechesis, education, pastoral visitation, and Marian devotion, approaches that reflected both his missionary formation and his appreciation of local cultural realities.²⁵

By the close of the 1950s, Usanga had established himself as one of the Diocese of Calabar's most promising young priests. In 1961, he left Nigeria for the United States of America for further studies. He obtained a bachelor's degree in philosophy from St Mary of the Plains College in Dodge City, Kansas, and a master's degree in the same discipline from St Louis University, Missouri, in 1963. He went further to the Catholic University of America in Washington, DC, where he obtained a doctorate in philosophical anthropology in 1966.²⁶ While studying, he served as Assistant Chaplain of the University, Confessor at the Immaculate Conception National Shrine, and Chaplain to the Pan-African and Nigerian Students Association. This inaugurated a new phase in his intellectual development and prepared him for the national and international leadership roles he would later assume.

Episcopacy and Humanitarianism during the Nigerian Civil War (1961–1970)

²² Most Rev. Brian Usanga, "Biographical Data" & Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.153–155.

²³ Cooke, *Bishop James Moynagh*, p.134.

²⁴ Edem, *Dominic Ignatius Ekandem*; Nwosuh, *Cardinal Dominic Ekandem*.

²⁵ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.164–167.

²⁶ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.191 & Nwosuh, *Cardinal Dominic Ekandem*, p.173

Across sub-Saharan Africa, the years surrounding political independence witnessed a deliberate transfer of ecclesiastical authority from expatriate missionaries to African bishops whose leadership would be grounded in both theological competence and cultural familiarity.²⁷ The confidence Bishop Moynagh had in Usanga culminated in his appointment as Auxiliary Bishop of Calabar by Pope Paul VI on August 4, 1966. His appointment formed part of the wider program of ecclesiastical indigenization that followed the Second Vatican Council and the political independence of many African states. Yet scarcely had Usanga assumed episcopal office when Nigeria descended into one of the gravest humanitarian catastrophes in modern African history, marked by the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970).²⁸ Recent scholarship, however, has increasingly emphasized its humanitarian dimensions, particularly the unprecedented displacement of civilians, widespread famine, and the emergence of faith-based organizations as indispensable providers of relief.²⁹ This perspective provides an important context for understanding Archbishop Usanga’s wartime leadership.

Contrary to popular assumptions, the humanitarian crisis did not begin with the formal declaration of the Republic of Biafra in May 1967. The crisis had already commenced following the anti-Igbo massacres of 1966, which forced hundreds of thousands of eastern Nigerians to abandon their homes in northern and western Nigeria and return to an already overstretched Eastern Region.³⁰ Catholic parishes, schools, and mission compounds became temporary shelters for displaced families long before armed hostilities began.³¹ Mission schools were converted into refugee camps, while diocesan authorities organized the collection of food and clothing as well as medical assistance and accommodation for returnees whose families could no longer absorb the growing numbers of internally displaced persons. These initiatives marked a renewed emphasis on *diaconia*—the Church’s ministry of service—as an integral dimension of Catholic witness.³²

²⁷ Elizabeth Isichei. *A History of Christianity in Africa: From Antiquity to the Present*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995.

²⁸ John de St. Jorre. *The Nigerian Civil War*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1972 & John Stremlau, *The International Politics of the Nigerian Civil War, 1967–1970*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1977.

²⁹ Heerten, Heerten, Lasse. *The Biafran War and Postcolonial Humanitarianism: Spectacles of Suffering*. New York: Cambridge, 2017; Okey Anueyiagu, *Biafra: The Horrors of War – The Story of a Child Soldier*, Atlanta, Brown Broomel: 2020; Edidiong Ekefre, “Faith-Based Humanitarian Intervention: The Catholic Church and the Biafran Refugee Crisis During the Nigerian Civil War, 1967–1970,” *International Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences*, (2024), 18(7), 318 – 326: & Edidiong Ekefre, “Breaking the blockades: international humanitarian organisations versus anti-humanitarian policies of the Nigerian government amidst Biafra humanitarian crisis during the Nigerian civil war, 1967–1970.” *SN Social Sciences* 5:126 (2025).

³⁰ Chinua Achebe, *There Was a Country: A Personal History*. New York: Penguin, 2012.

³¹ Ekefre, “Faith-Based Humanitarian Intervention.”

³² Francis Arinze, Interview by the author, Onitsha, 2018; Vincent Nwosu, “The Civil War Years: A Time of Great Trial,” in *A Hundred Years of the Catholic Church in Eastern Nigeria, 1885–1985* by Celestine Obi et al (ed.) (Onitsha, Africana-FEP: 1985), p. 358.

This humanitarian orientation profoundly shaped Usanga's ministry after he was elected the first Nigerian Secretary-General of the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria in 1967. The office placed him at the centre of relations between the Catholic Church, the Federal Military Government, international relief agencies, and the global Catholic community at precisely the moment when Nigeria entered civil war. The collapse of civil administration across much of the Eastern Region required church leaders to function simultaneously as diplomats, humanitarian coordinators, advocates for civilian populations, and custodians of fragile channels of international assistance.

Before the outbreak of full-scale hostilities, Usanga participated in ecumenical initiatives aimed at preventing armed conflict through dialogue between political and military authorities. Although these efforts ultimately failed, they reflected a broader commitment among Nigerian Christian leaders to peacebuilding and national reconciliation.³³ Once war commenced, humanitarian responsibilities expanded dramatically. Millions of civilians found themselves trapped within blockaded territories where food shortages, disease, and displacement became everyday realities. The Federal Military Government's blockade of the secessionist territory, intended to weaken Biafra's military capacity, also produced devastating consequences for the civilian population, particularly women and children.³⁴

As relief needs escalated, the Catholic Church appealed to international partners for assistance. Within this international humanitarian network, *Caritas Internationalis* emerged as the principal Catholic relief agency, working alongside organizations such as the World Council of Churches, Catholic Relief Services, Misereor, Oxfam, and the International Committee of the Red Cross.³⁵ These organizations organized one of the largest humanitarian airlift operations in twentieth-century Africa, transporting food, medicines, clothing, and medical supplies into the besieged Biafran enclave despite enormous political and military obstacles.³⁶

As Secretary-General of the Catholic Secretariat of Nigeria, Usanga occupied a uniquely sensitive position within these developments. His responsibilities extended beyond coordinating ecclesiastical responses inside Nigeria. He also undertook diplomatic missions to Europe and North America to reassure foreign episcopal conferences and Catholic agencies that humanitarian assistance was motivated by concern for civilian welfare rather than political support for secession. Usanga traveled to Ireland, England and the United States of America in 1969 as a special delegate of

³³ Nwosu, "The Civil War Years, p.359.

³⁴ St. Jorre, *The Nigerian Civil War*; Stremlau, *The International Politics*; & Edidiong Ekefre, "Hosting Biafran Child-Refugees: The Inter-African Refugee and International Humanitarian Network System during the Nigerian Civil War, 1967 and Beyond," *Journal of Migration Studies*, Vol. 9 (2023), 269-296; & Ekefre, "Faith-Based Humanitarian Intervention."

³⁵ Francis Arinze, Oral Interview, Onitsha, 2018; Nwosu, "The Civil War Years"; & Ekefre, "Breaking the blockades"

³⁶ Peter Canning et al (Production Team). "Night Flight to Uli" A Documentary, A HARHARS Presentation found in the archives of the Congregation of the Missionary Sisters of the Holy Rosary, Killeshandra, Co. Cavan, Ireland, 1968.

the Nigerian bishops for a meeting with the Episcopal Conferences abroad to appeal for help and prayer for lasting peace and reconciliation in Nigeria.

In Ireland, Usanga had a one-hour private audience with the Irish President, Eamon de Valera. In Northern Ireland, he met with the missionaries cut off from the mission territory to brief them on up-to-date information on the crises.³⁷ In the United States of America, he met with prominent Catholic prelates and missionary leaders. In Italy and Germany, he met with leaders of Catholic humanitarian organizations such as Caritas International and Misereor: “There he obtained money, kit-cars, gifts from Pope Paul VI, a plane full of drugs, and shipments of stockfish and other foodstuffs for the war.”³⁸ Such diplomacy became increasingly necessary as the Federal Military Government accused several international relief agencies of prolonging the conflict through blockade-breaking airlifts.³⁹ Usanga’s measured diplomacy sought to preserve both the Church’s humanitarian credibility and its capacity to continue assisting civilian populations.

Recent scholarship has also demonstrated that humanitarian intervention during the Civil War cannot be understood exclusively through the experiences of the Igbo heartland. Minority communities in present-day Akwa Ibom, Cross River, Rivers, and Bayelsa States likewise experienced extensive displacement and often received comparatively limited governmental assistance. Catholic dioceses in the former South-Eastern State established refugee camps, converted schools and parish facilities into centres of relief distribution, and relied heavily upon indigenous clergy and local communities to sustain displaced populations. These efforts demonstrated that humanitarian intervention in southeastern Nigeria depended not only on international relief agencies but also on local Catholic institutions and African communal solidarity, with Usanga in Calabar, along with his counterpart, Ekandem, at Ikot Ekpene, playing a significant role.⁴⁰ As Stremlau observed, humanitarian organizations became caught between the competing imperatives of state sovereignty and the moral obligation to preserve human life.⁴¹ Usanga’s leadership reflected a careful attempt to navigate this difficult terrain by maintaining the Church’s commitment to humanitarian neutrality while insisting upon the primacy of human dignity.

Rebuilding an Indigenous Humanitarian Church: Archbishop of Calabar (1970–1999)

³⁷ Most Rev. Brian Usanga, “Biographical Data” published in the Souvenir programme of his Episcopal Silver Jubilee Celebration, 1-8 December 1991.

³⁸ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p.216/217; & Most Rev. Brian Usanga, “Biographical Data”

³⁹ Stremlau 1977; Canning et al, “Night Flight to Uli”; & Ekefre, “Hosting Biafran Child-Refugees.”

⁴⁰ Edidiong Ekefre, *A Testament of Light: The Life and Times of Dominic Cardinal Ekandem*, Lagos, Mayfive Media, 2013; Christopher Umoh, Oral Interview, Ikot Ekpene, 2012; Asuquo, Oral Interview, Ikot Ekpene, 2012; & Sylvanus Etok, Oral Interview, Ikot Ekpene, 2012.

⁴¹ Stremlau, *The International Politics*.

The end of the Nigerian Civil War in January 1970 marked the beginning of an equally demanding phase of Usanga's ministry. Churches, schools, hospitals, seminaries, convents, and parish infrastructures had suffered widespread destruction, while thousands of families struggled with displacement, poverty, bereavement, and social dislocation.⁴² It was within this context that Usanga succeeded Bishop James Moynagh as the first indigenous Bishop of Calabar on August 30, 1970. The transition from missionary to indigenous episcopal leadership coincided with Nigeria's broader program of post-war reconstruction and national indigenization process.

In 1970, after becoming the substantive bishop of Calabar, Bishop Usanga sent five seminarians to Rome to study for the priesthood. However, they all abandoned their priestly vocation for other aspirations in Europe and America. Also, in 1971, he sent twenty-one seminarians in a single batch to SS Peter and Paul Major Seminary, Ibadan. They were evidence of his passion for the vocation to the priesthood channelled towards the indigenisation of the Nigerian Church. However, as a negative effect of the Civil War, out of the twenty-one seminarians sent to Ibadan, only seven succeeded in being ordained to the Catholic priesthood. In effect, Usanga decided to compose a prayer titled "Prayer for Indigenous Vocations," which was prayed regularly at the end of every Eucharistic celebration throughout the diocese of Calabar. An excerpt of this prayer goes thus: "Give us your grace so that many Priests, Sisters, Brothers, and other servants of yours may come from among us to lead our people and enable them to know and have you, their true and just God and Jesus Christ whom you have sent."⁴³

One of Usanga's earliest priorities was the rehabilitation of Catholic educational institutions. Building upon the Church's longstanding educational tradition inherited from the missionary era, Usanga encouraged the reopening of schools, the establishment of new educational institutions, and the recruitment and formation of qualified teachers.⁴⁴ However, barely three months after the war, schools were taken over first, in the East Central State in 1970.⁴⁵ The new policy became very fashionable and spread like wildfire to other states of the federation, including the South-Eastern State, where the diocese of Calabar was situated, in 1971.⁴⁶

In 1975, the federal government of Nigeria officially promulgated a decree legitimizing the action of states that had taken over schools from the Church. In 1977, the Obasanjo-led government enacted a decree validating the takeover of schools in

⁴² Ekefre, "Faith-Based Humanitarian Intervention"

⁴³ Brian Usanga, *Efik Hymn and Prayer Book*, Calabar, Catholic Archdiocese of Calabar, 1974.

⁴⁴ Emmanuel Ating, Oral Interview, Calabar, 2026 & Michael Etim, Oral Interview, Calabar, 2026.

⁴⁵ Francis Arinze, Oral Interview, Onitsha, September 2018; Udoidem, "Church-State Relationship in Education."; A. E. Afigbo, "The Mission, the State and Education in South-Eastern Nigeria (1956-1971)" in *Christianity in Independent Nigeria* by Edward Fashole-Luke et al (ed), (London, Rex Collins: 1978), p.17; Colman Cooke, "Church, State and Education: The Eastern Nigeria Experience, 1050-67" in *Christianity in Independent Nigeria* by Edward Fashole-Luke et al (ed), (London, Rex Collins: 1978), p.200

⁴⁶ Iniobong Udoidem, Oral Interview, Uyo, 2026.

Nigeria.⁴⁷ In reaction to this, Usanga, under the mandate of the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria, negotiated for a return of mission schools to the Church but to no avail. In the diocese of Calabar, he led a delegation of the bishops of the present-day Calabar province to the then governor of the South-Eastern State, Dan Patrick Archibong, a Catholic, but without success except to retain the original mission names that depicted the missionary heritage of the schools.⁴⁸

The Church-State crisis regarding mission schools did not deter Usanga from investing in education and other religious sites of worship. Under his leadership, Immaculate Conception, Mfamosing; Cardinal Ekandem Minor Seminary, Uyo; Stella Maris Minor Seminary, Uyanga; Marium Spiritual Year Seminary, Calabar; Assumption Girls' Juniorate, Ndon Ebom; Mary Immaculate Girls' Juniorate, Iwuru; and many other schools and Bible colleges were founded within the diocese of Calabar. He also built two shrines in honor of Our Lady: the Immaculate Conception Shrine in his hometown, Obotim, and the Our Lady of Fatima Shrine in Calabar.⁴⁹

Healthcare also remained central to his pastoral priorities. The humanitarian experiences of the Civil War had demonstrated the indispensable role of Catholic hospitals and clinics in serving vulnerable populations. Consequently, Usanga encouraged the rehabilitation and expansion of mission health facilities, particularly in rural communities where government services remained limited.⁵⁰ Ecclesiastically, his episcopate witnessed significant institutional growth. New parishes were established to serve expanding Catholic populations, catechetical programs were strengthened, and lay participation in parish administration increased considerably following the reforms of the Second Vatican Council.

Under Usanga's episcopacy, the diocese of Calabar was elevated to the status of a Metropolitan See, the archdiocese of Calabar, on March 31, 1994. On August 17, 1994, Usanga was formally installed as Archbishop of Calabar, where he served until his retirement in 2003 at the age of seventy-five. His last pastoral activity as the Archbishop of Calabar was the ordination of six candidates into the Catholic priesthood on August 16, 2003 to mark the centenary of the Catholic mission in Calabar. Overall, while heading the Church in Calabar, Usanga ordained eighty-nine Catholic priests between December 5, 1969, and August 16, 2003.⁵¹

As the first Metropolitan Archbishop, Usanga guided the province through a period of remarkable consolidation, fostering collaboration among the dioceses of the ecclesiastical province while encouraging pastoral initiatives responsive to the changing realities of Nigerian society. On October 25, 2003, Usanga celebrated his seventy-fifth birthday, platinum jubilee, to mark his official exit from office as the Local Ordinary

⁴⁷ Udoidem, Oral Interview.

⁴⁸ Joseph Ukpo, Oral Interview, Calabar, 2014; & Edidiong Ekefre, *A Testament of Peace: The Biography of His Grace Archbishop Joseph Ukpo* (Abuja, Commonwealth Media: 2015), 150.

⁴⁹ Benedict Emeh, Oral Interview, Uyo, 2026.

⁵⁰ Joseph Ekarika, Oral Interview, Calabar, 2012.

⁵¹ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*, p. 15.

of Calabar. He was succeeded by Bishop Joseph Edra Ukpo on December 19, 2003.⁵² Less than two years later, on May 26, 2005, Usanga died in Rome after a protracted illness. He was buried at the Sacred Heart Cathedral, Calabar, where he served for thirty-three years.⁵³

Conclusion

Brian Davis Usanga occupies a distinguished place in the history of African Christianity because his life embodied several of the defining transformations that shaped the Catholic Church in twentieth-century Nigeria. His episcopacy coincided with Nigeria's most turbulent decades. During the Civil War, he emerged as a humanitarian leader, ecclesiastical diplomat, and advocate for civilian populations caught in one of Africa's greatest humanitarian disasters. In the post-war period, he devoted himself to rebuilding educational institutions, strengthening healthcare services, expanding pastoral structures, promoting indigenous clergy, and fostering reconciliation within a deeply divided society. These achievements demonstrate that his contribution extended far beyond diocesan administration.

Ultimately, Usanga's enduring legacy rests in his successful integration of evangelization, humanitarian service, education, and institution building. His life illustrates the evolution of the Catholic Church in southeastern Nigeria from a missionary-founded institution into an indigenous ecclesial community capable of responding creatively to the complex political, humanitarian, and developmental challenges of postcolonial Africa. His ministry, therefore, deserves recognition not only within the history of the Archdiocese of Calabar but also within the broader history of African Christianity, where he stands as one of the leading architects of an indigenous Church committed equally to faith, human dignity, and national transformation.

Bibliography

- Achebe, Chinua. *There Was a Country: A Personal History*. New York: Penguin, 2012.
- Afigbo, A. E. "The Mission, the State and Education in South-Eastern Nigeria (1956-1971)" in *Christianity in Independent Nigeria* by Edward Fashole-Luke et al (ed), (London, Rex Collins: 1978).
- Akpan, Asuquo. Oral Interview, Ikot Ekpene, 2012.
- Anueyiagu, Okey. *Biafra: The Horrors of War – The Story of a Child Soldier*, Atlanta, Brown Brommel: 2020.
- Arinze, Francis. Oral Interview, Onitsha, September 2018
- Ating, Emmanuel. Oral Interview, Uyo, 2026.
- Biography of Most Rev Dr Brian Usanga," Souvenir Programme of 70th Birthday, 24 October 1998.

⁵² Ekefre, *A Testament of Peace*, p.213

⁵³ Etim, *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga*.

- Bishop Moynagh's Recollection" in Christopher McGuiness (ed.), *Souvenir of Silver Jubilee of Episcopal Ordination of His Eminence Cardinal Dominic Ekanem, Bishop of Ikot Ekpene, 1954-1979*.
- Canning, Peter et al (Production Team). "Night Flight to Uli," A Documentary, A HARHARS Presentation found in the archives of the Congregation of the Missionary Sisters of the Holy Rosary, Killeshandra, Co. Cavan, Ireland, 1968.
- Cooke, Colman. "Church, State and Education: The Eastern Nigeria Experience, 1050-67" in *Christianity in Independent Nigeria* by Edward Fashole-Luke et al (ed), (London, Rex Collins: 1978), p.200
- Cooke, Colman. *Bishop James Moynagh of Calabar*, Dublin, The Columba Press: 2014.
- Edem, Michael. *Dominic Ignatius Ekanem, 1917-1995: The Prince who became a Cardinal – The Vanguard of Catholicism in Nigeria*, Uyo, Minno Prints: 2016.
- Ekarika, Joseph. Oral Interview, Calabar, 2012.
- Ekefre, Edidiong. "Breaking the blockades: international humanitarian organisations versus anti-humanitarian policies of the Nigerian government amidst Biafra humanitarian crisis during the Nigerian civil war, 1967–1970." *SN Social Sciences* 5:126 (2025).
- Ekefre, Edidiong. "Faith-Based Humanitarian Intervention: The Catholic Church and the Biafran Refugee Crisis During the Nigerian Civil War, 1967-1970," *International Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences*, (2024), 18(7), 318 – 326.
- Ekefre, Edidiong. "Hosting Biafran Child-Refugees: The Inter-African Refugee and International Humanitarian Network System during the Nigerian Civil War, 1967 and beyond," *Journal of Migration Studies*, Vol. 9 (2023), 269-296.
- Ekefre, Edidiong. *A Testament of Light: The Life and Times of Dominic Cardinal Ekanem*, Lagos, Mayfive Media, 2013
- Ekefre, Edidiong. *A Testament of Peace: The Biography of His Grace Archbishop Joseph Ukpo* (Abuja, Commonwealth Media, 2015).
- Emeh, Benedict. Oral Interview, Uyo, 2026.
- Etim, Charles. *Archbishop Brian Davis Usanga: The Shepherd with a Heart of Gold*, Abuja, Paulines, 2021.
- Etim, Michael. Oral Interview, Calabar, 2026.
- Etok, Sylvanus. Oral Interview, Ikot Ekpene, 2012.
- Falola, Toyin. *The History of Nigeria*. Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 1999.
- Fashole-Luke, Edward et al (ed). *Christianity in Independent Nigeria* (London, Rex Collins: 1978)
- Heerten, Lasse. *The Biafran War and Postcolonial Humanitarianism: Spectacles of Suffering*. New York: Cambridge, 2017.
- Isichei, Elizabeth. *A History of Christianity in Africa: From Antiquity to the Present*. Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1995.
- Kiggins, Thomas. *Maynooth Mission to Africa: The Story of St Patrick's Kiltegan*. Dublin: Gill & Macmillan, 1991.
- Most Rev. Brian Usanga, "Biographical Data" published in the Souvenir programme of his Episcopal Silver Jubilee Celebration, 1-8 December 1991.
- Nwosu, Vincent. "The Civil War Years: A Time of Great Trial," in *A Hundred Years of*

- the Catholic Church in Eastern Nigeria, 1885-1985* by Celestine Obi et al (ed.) (Onitsha, Africana-FEP: 1985).
- Nwosuh, Cosmas. *Cardinal Dominic Ekandem and the Growth of the Catholic Church in Nigeria*, Abuja, Ambassador, 2012.
- Obi, Celestine et al (ed.) *A Hundred Years of the Catholic Church in Eastern Nigeria, 1885-1985*, Onitsha, Africana-FEP: 1985.
- St. Jorre, John de. *The Nigerian Civil War*. London: Hodder and Stoughton, 1972
- Stremlau, John J. *The International Politics of the Nigerian Civil War, 1967–1970*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1977.
- Udoidem, Iniobong. “Church-State Relationship in Education”
- Udoidem, Iniobong. Oral Interview, Uyo, 2026.
- Ukpo, Joseph. Oral Interview, Calabar, 2014.
- Umoh, Christopher. Oral Interview, Ikot Ekpene, 2012.
- Usanga, Brian. *Efik Hymn and Prayer Book*, Calabar, Catholic Archdiocese of Calabar, 1974.

This biography, received in July 2026, was written by Edidiong Ekefre, a Catholic priest from the Diocese of Uyo, Nigeria. He holds a doctoral degree in African History from the University of the Witwatersrand, South Africa. Specializing in War and Humanitarian Studies, Ekefre is also a biographer and a lecturer in History and International Studies at Akwa Ibom State University, Nigeria.

Poem

Excerpt from *Songs of Childhood: Biafran War Memories* by Nimi Wariboko.
Abuja, Nigeria: Paperworth Books, 2025.

#11 Child at War

I speak
after the horrors of war,
from the pits of its cruel belly,
out of the depths of my isolation,
trauma, the silhouette of my pain.

I speak,
Dimama, Grace's son
and Elekima's.
My village bombed and broken—
our Nyemoni crumbled to Biafran rule.

Driven and tossed
from nativity to sanctuary.

We returned,
in the company of the federal forces
who bombed our town,
my voice, smooth like water,
drained into my stomach

in its place, the vestige of war,
a stutter and long silences.

The war wounded me, I was a child
too tender for eternal scars.

This poem is one of a collection that “offers a vivid recounting of the Civil War events through the lense of a child (...). I am that child, and the accounts here focus on my experience as a six-year-old in 1968 when the Nigerian Civil War came to my town, Abonnema (Nyemoni), Rivers State, Nigeria. (...) Usually, stories of war are tales of grandeur, involving big people and big places, whereas the ignored people and places suffer similar and even sometimes more gruesome fates. This is a historical document. The story of the Abonnema people, for the Abonnema people, the country at large, and the wider world.”

Nimi Wariboko, Walter G. Muelder Professor of Social Ethics at Boston University and Chair of the Executive Committee of the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography*.

Introducing: *Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Catholic Women in Nigeria*, Volume 1⁵⁴

By Sr. Dr Elizabeth Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA



Across generations, the history of the Church has often privileged the voices of the prominent, leaving many quiet yet influential contributors in the shadows. The stories contained in *The Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Catholic Women in Nigeria, Vol. 1*, help correct this imbalance by illuminating the lives of women whose faith, sacrifice, and leadership have shaped Catholic communities across the country. Their contributions – spiritual, social, cultural, and even political – form an essential part of Nigeria’s Christian heritage. This volume is from the Unsung African Women Heroes of Faith Pan African Project, launched in 2024.

For decades, theological and historical accounts have centered predominantly on male figures, leaving women’s contributions underexplored or entirely absent. This collection challenges that imbalance by foregrounding mothers, catechists, teachers, farmers, religious sisters, widows, community organizers, and prayer warriors whose lives embodied courage, compassion, perseverance, and hope. Many of these women endured war, poverty, marginalization, and cultural resistance, yet their faith remained deeply rooted in lived experience.

Their ministries, often informal and sustained with limited resources, built churches, nurtured families, established schools, and strengthened communities in ways that formal records rarely captured. Their witness was expressed not through public recognition but through quiet acts of service, intercessory prayer, community building, and steadfast devotion to the Gospel.

Through careful research, oral histories, and community testimonies, this project seeks to give voice to women whose fidelity to God left an enduring mark on the church. Their stories challenge narrow understandings of spiritual authority and broaden our appreciation of how faith is lived and transmitted. By presenting these accounts, the volume contributes to a more inclusive and accurate telling of African Christian history.

As these profiles enter the *Journal of African Christian Biography*, they offer scholars, clergy, and readers a valuable resource and a source of inspiration. They remind us that profound spiritual influence is often found not in public acclaim but in hidden acts of courage, generosity, and love. May these stories encourage deeper recognition of the women who have quietly sustained the Church and shaped its future.

⁵⁴ *Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Catholic Women in Nigeria*, vol. 1, edited by Sr. Dr. Elizabeth Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA (African Catholic Press [AfriCaP], Catholic Diocesan Secretariate Complex, 3rd Floor, off Nnobi Road, Nnewi, Anambra State, Nigeria. A 50-minute documentary of the volume can be viewed here: <https://youtu.be/wihmXTKkRMI>.

~Sr. Dr. Titilayo and the publisher have graciously given the JACB permission to reprint three of the eighteen biographies in the volume as well as an introductory essay written by Dr. Stan Chu Ilo for the volume.

~ ~ ~

Life of Madam Anna Daboh (1903-1988)

Early Life, Conversion and Education

Madam Anna Daboh, a revered Catholic matriarch and religious mobilizer, was born around 1903 in the ancient Tiv settlement near Zaki Biam, in the present-day Ukum Local Government Area of Benue State, Nigeria. Born into a traditional agrarian family, Anna was the daughter of Ichôô Aondofa and Mngohol Iveren. Her family was well-known for its morals, discipline, community values, and strong ties to ancestral religious practices. Anna exhibited a natural strength of character, courage, and a passion for truth from childhood. However, a significant transformation would mark her destiny: the arrival of Catholic missionaries in Tiv-land. Though she was born into a deeply traditional environment, her heart was drawn to the new Christian message preached by the missionaries. During her teenage years, she encountered the Catholic faith through early missionary catechists who taught basic doctrine using vernacular translations and illustrative Bible stories. By 1918, when she was around 15 years old, she was baptized after a period of catechetical instruction.

Formal education was nearly nonexistent for girls in Tiv-land at that time, as cultural beliefs strongly prioritized domestic roles for girls and women. Anna, like many other girls, did not attend a Western-style of schooling. Nevertheless, she received informal instruction from the missionaries and her husband, John Adzuana Daboh, the first known Tiv Catholic catechist. Through her husband's influence, she learned basic reading, Catholic prayers, liturgical responses, and songs, all of which she would later teach to others. Her intellectual curiosity and faith made her a formidable woman of learning, despite her lack of formal education.

Anna was known to memorize long sections of the catechism and Bible stories. She was also a good storyteller who used traditional Tiv proverbs and folktales to explain Christian values to women and children. Her sharp memory, clarity of expression, and natural charisma laid the groundwork for the remarkable leadership role she would later assume in both the Church and community.

Marital and Family Life

Anna's marriage to John Adzuana Daboh was a union of faith and purpose. John had been one of the early converts to Catholicism and was selected by Irish missionaries in Makurdi to serve as a lay catechist among the Tiv. Their marriage in 1923 was

not only a domestic bond but a partnership in mission. Anna supported her husband's evangelistic efforts by helping him establish catechetical centers, organizing women, and welcoming new converts into the faith. The couple had six children, though only two survived into adulthood. Like many families of the era, they faced the painful reality of high infant mortality rates. Nonetheless, Anna remained a nurturing figure not only to her biological children but also to numerous adopted children, orphans, and young girls from surrounding villages. She believed every child deserved love and education and went out of her way to ensure they were raised in the Catholic tradition. Their home in Zaki Biam became an informal mission station. During long treks and preaching tours, Anna managed the household and led morning and evening prayers with the local women and children. When John, her husband, died in 1951 after a short illness, Anna took up more visible leadership responsibilities, stepping into a role once dominated by her husband.

Contributions to the Church and Evangelical Work

Madam Anna Daboh's work in the Church went far beyond what was expected of women during her time. She emerged as a trailblazer in the organization of women's apostolate in Catholic parishes throughout Tiv-land. In the mid-1930s, she began hosting gatherings for women to reflect on the Sunday Gospel, pray the Rosary, and discuss family challenges. These gatherings gradually evolved into the Catholic Women Organization (CWO) in Tiv-land. In 1942, Anna visited the mission station at Otukpo for a Marian celebration and witnessed a vibrant women's sodality. Inspired by their structure and communal spirit, she returned to Zaki Biam, determined to replicate it. By 1945, with the support of the missionary priests, she formally established the Tiv Women Apostolate Group, later renamed the Catholic Women Organization (CWO) in Tivland in 1948. Her initiatives included:

- Formation of prayer groups in local parishes
- Teaching women how to read prayers in Tiv
- Organizing training workshops on motherhood, family planning, and catechesis
- Coordinating Lenten reflections and May/October
- devotions
- Organizing fundraisers for mission schools and orphanages

Anna also pioneered catechists' training programmes for women and insisted on including women in liturgical functions such as readings, offertory processions, and choirs. She was also a strong proponent of the Legion of Mary and, by 1955, had formed three praesidia for women and youth in the Ukum and Katsina-Ala regions.

Contributions to Community Work

While Anna Daboh was a devout churchwoman, her vision extended to the larger society. She saw Catholicism not merely as a way of life but as a transformative force for justice, dignity, and social upliftment. She took on the challenge of reorienting a society

that often devalued women and marginalized people with low incomes. Anna pioneered the fight for the education of the girl child in Tiv-land. She sponsored several young girls to attend mission schools in Katsina-Ala, Gboko, and Aliade. Many of these girls became teachers and midwives who, in turn, helped raise awareness of health and hygiene in their own communities. Anna also challenged parents who denied their daughters' education, arguing that "the wisdom of a woman builds the family and society."

Mama Anna was a vocal opponent of early marriage; she often mediated in cases where girls were forcibly taken as child brides. Her advocacy led to changes in several family practices and opened the minds of many traditional elders to embrace modern values. Anna's home became a refuge for widows, orphans, and displaced families. During the inter-tribal clashes in 1953 and 1960 in parts of Benue, she housed dozens of families displaced by the conflict. She organized food drives, distributed clothing, and comforted bereaved families. She led Christian burial prayers even in times when priests were unavailable.

Participation in Church

Anna Daboh was the spiritual lifeblood of her parish community. Every morning, long before sunrise, she would trek, praying the Rosary, to St. John's Catholic Church in Zaki Biam to attend 5:30 am Mass. Her routine included praying the Angelus daily at noon and 6:00 pm, often gathering neighbours to pray together. On Sundays, she led the choir and women's group, taught catechumens preparing for baptism and marriage, and visited the sick parishioners. She had a particular devotion to the Blessed Virgin Mary and introduced the practice of home Marian altars. She also had a unique role in parish reporting. When priests visited the village, Anna gave them updates on community life, reporting those who were sick, preparing for sacraments, or in need of church support. She was practically the unofficial catechist and administrator of the outstation.

Relationship with Clergy and Religious

Anna's home served as a guesthouse for priests and religious serving in the Eastern Tiv-land region. At a time when road infrastructure was poor and motorbikes were a luxury, priests relied on laypersons like Anna for lodging, food, and logistical support. Her compound had a small "guest hut" where priests lodged when ministering in the region. She not only provided meals and water but also spiritual companionship. She would often lead morning prayers with them, share updates on the local faithful, and even offer counsel on sensitive family matters brought to the Church. Her interactions with priests were marked by mutual respect and admiration. Many priests described her as "the matriarch of faith."

Flaws and Challenges

Though revered, Madam Anna Daboh was not without flaws. She was fiercely principled and had a reputation for being unbending. Her insistence on high moral standards sometimes caused tensions, especially with younger women who felt judged or misunderstood. She could be blunt and openly criticized what she considered un-Christian behavior, whether from church members or local elders. Her assertiveness was often misinterpreted by some men in the community who felt threatened by a woman who spoke so boldly. There were moments when she clashed with traditional authorities over funeral rites, inheritance issues, or the role of women in village councils. She was also deeply saddened by being widowed early and having few surviving biological children. Though she embraced spiritual motherhood and community leadership, the personal pain of loss lingered throughout her life. Yet, she turned this pain into empathy and used her experience to comfort countless other women facing similar grief.

Legacy and Remembrance

Madam Anna Daboh passed away in 1988 at the age of 85. Her funeral Mass was held at St. John's Parish, Zaki Biam, with over a thousand people in attendance, including clergy, religious, and faithful from Makurdi, Gboko, and Otukpo dioceses. She is remembered as the mother of the Catholic Women's Apostolate in Tiv-land, a fearless evangelist, and a servant of Christ. Madam Anna Daboh's life stands as a powerful testimony to the potential of women in building both faith and society. Through her courage, faith, and wisdom, she helped shape the Catholic identity of an entire region. In an era when women's voices were suppressed, she rose gracefully and tenaciously, blazing a trail that countless others would follow. Her legacy is engraved on plaques and memorials and in the living hearts of the people and the Church she served.

Sources:

Aondonengen Michael Sesugh (Former Catechist, St. John Catholic Church Cathedral, Gboko Diocese)

Mrs Euchariah Orhungul (Diocesan CWO, President Makurdi Diocese)

Researchers:

Alexander Okonnu and Sr. Joy James, SFS

Life of Mama Rebecca Hamza (1942–2007)

Early Life, Conversion, and Education



Mama Rebecca Hamza was born on October 14, 1942, in the town of Takum, Taraba State, to Mallam Haruna Angyu and Ma'a Briskila Angyu. The people of Takum, steeped in the tradition of storytelling and oral history, often gathered at dusk to share tales of triumph, loss, and faith. This vibrant cultural backdrop profoundly shaped Rebecca's early years, instilling in her a deep appreciation for the power of narratives and communal wisdom. Her father, Mallam Haruna Angyu, was both a dedicated teacher and a passionate evangelist. He spent his days imparting knowledge in the classroom and nurturing spiritual growth in the community. His unwavering commitment to education and faith created an enriching environment where Rebecca developed both intellectual curiosity and a strong moral foundation. Meanwhile, her mother, Ma'a Briskila, embodied warmth and compassion, fostering a home where prayer was an integral part of daily life and acts of kindness were a natural expression of faith. It was this nurturing environment that shaped Rebecca's character and instilled in her a deep sense of compassion and service.

From a young age, Rebecca absorbed her father's lessons, mimicking his gentle recitations and reflecting on the wisdom he shared. Her surroundings also played an integral role in her development—the lively chatter of market vendors, the rhythmic call to prayer, and the natural symphony of rustling trees and birdsong provided the backdrop to her formative years. Educators in Takum, many of whom were respected community elders, nurtured not just academic excellence but also ethical growth. Their classrooms were spaces where morality and scholarship were deeply connected, shaping Rebecca's critical thinking and empathy. She was naturally inquisitive, eager to question societal norms and to explore the deeper implications of her learning. Her favorite subjects delved into existential and moral inquiries, fueling her lifelong pursuit of knowledge as a tool for both personal growth and communal upliftment. Rebecca's passion for education was evident from an early age. She attended Lupwe Primary School from 1950 to 1956, then proceeded to Gindiri Girls' College from 1959 to 1964, where she earned her Grade 1 and 2 Teacher's Certificates. In 1970, she completed her studies in French at the Advanced Teachers' College in Zaria. Her academic journey continued with a Bachelor of Arts in Language Arts from Ahmadu Bello University in 1980, followed by a Master of Arts in English Curriculum from the University of Jos.

Rebecca's teenage years were marked by challenges that tested her faith and resilience. As modern ideas began clashing with traditional values, she found herself at a crossroads. She observed the struggles affecting her community—land disputes, the tensions between modernity and tradition, and the ever-present economic hardships. While many of her peers were drawn to fleeting distractions, Rebecca found solace in quiet reflection and prayer. These challenges only strengthened her resolve to be a beacon of hope. With a growing desire to serve, she took on responsibilities beyond her years—tutoring younger children, assisting in community events, and even mediating disputes. Her mentors recalled instances where, after challenging days, she would retreat to a quiet corner of the local church to pray fervently, not just for herself, but for those in need. Through this practice, she realized that true faith extended beyond personal devotion—it was a call to action, a commitment to the well-being of others.

Marriage and Family Life

As Rebecca's public work gained momentum, she embarked on a profound personal journey alongside her husband, Anthony Leginto Hamza. Their relationship began at a communal prayer session, where they discovered a shared passion for faith, education, and service to others. Hamza, known for his integrity and kindness, quickly became an essential part of Rebecca's life. On August 6, 1965, Rebecca married Hamza, a fellow educator and devout Christian. Their marriage was characterized by a strong foundation of love, faith, and a deep sense of duty. Together, they supported each other's careers, navigating the challenges of professional and family life with dedication and perseverance. Their shared values of faith, education, and service not only strengthened their bond but also became the cornerstone of their life's work. Their partnership was a testament to the power of shared values in building a strong and enduring relationship.

Their marriage was blessed with five children, three of whom survived into adulthood: Paul B. Hamza, Mary M. Udoh, and Vyinu A. Sanya. Mama Rebecca was a nurturing mother who instilled in her children the values of discipline, kindness, and faith. She taught them Scripture, encouraged them to engage with music, and emphasized the importance of ethical living. The household was a place where faith was practiced openly, where hymns echoed through the rooms, and where guests were welcomed with generosity and prayer. Friends, relatives, and even strangers found refuge in their warmth and hospitality. No guest left without a meal, a heartfelt conversation, or a moment of prayer. Rebecca and Hamza believed that true faith was demonstrated through acts of kindness, and they sought to create an environment where love and service flourished.

As they raised their children, they instilled in them the principle that family life was an extension of their broader mission. Their home was not separate from their work; it was a place where values were taught, responsibilities were shared, and faith was lived out in everyday moments. They believed that the lessons learned within the family should translate into meaningful contributions to the community.

Despite the challenges that life presented, Rebecca and Hamza found strength

in each other. They faced difficulties with resilience, supporting one another through hardships and celebrating victories together. Their partnership became a model for others, demonstrating that a strong marriage could serve as both a source of personal fulfilment and a catalyst for positive change. In the quiet moments of the evening, after the day's work had ended, Mama Rebecca and Pa Hamza would sit together in reflection, cherishing their shared journey. Their love was not only a personal blessing but also a guiding force that inspired those around them. Through their commitment to family, faith, and service, they left a legacy of unity, compassion, and dedication to the greater good.

The Beginnings of a Life of Service

Rebecca's early adulthood marked a turning point in her journey as her dedication to service became more defined. With a keen intellect shaped by years of academic pursuit and a heart strengthened by life's challenges, she ventured beyond Takum to participate in community outreach programmes, educational seminars, and spiritual retreats. These experiences expanded her understanding of the world, exposing her to the everyday struggles of ordinary people. Traveling to neighboring villages and towns, Mama Rebecca witnessed firsthand the difficulties faced by rural communities, including limited access to healthcare, scarce educational opportunities, and persistent poverty. These encounters deepened her understanding of service, shifting it from an abstract idea to a tangible commitment. She realized that accurate service required direct engagement and practical solutions to bring meaningful change to people's lives.

Returning to Takum with renewed determination, Mama Rebecca began laying the foundation for initiatives that would later define her legacy. Collaborating with local leaders and educators, she developed programmes to improve both academic and spiritual development. One of her first major projects was establishing a modest schoolhouse to provide basic education for children in underserved areas. What began as a small effort soon evolved into a thriving learning centre, welcoming students from diverse backgrounds. Mama Rebecca believed in the transformative power of education, not just as a tool for intellectual growth but as a force for personal and communal development. She emphasized that learning was a lifelong process, requiring both the engagement of the mind and the dedication of the heart. Her studies encompassed subjects such as mathematics, literature, theology, and civic leadership, all woven together with a deep commitment to ethical instruction and spiritual reflection.

During this period, Rebecca's philosophy of service took shape through hands-on involvement in her community. She organized literacy classes during the day and prayer meetings in the evenings, merging education with spiritual nourishment. Her approach was holistic - academic achievement reinforced spiritual growth, and spiritual wisdom inspired practical solutions to everyday challenges. She took on responsibilities without hesitation, mobilizing volunteers for community projects, resolving local disputes, and offering guidance where it was needed most. The projects she initiated

were small in scale but had far-reaching effects. Beyond improving the quality of life, they instilled in the community a renewed sense of hope and unity. Through faith and perseverance, Rebecca cultivated a ministry rooted in both compassion and action. These formative years laid the groundwork for her lifelong dedication to service, shaping her life's mission.

Community Service and Leadership

Mama Rebecca's dedication to education and community service extended far beyond Takum, evolving into regionally recognized initiatives that impacted countless lives. She believed that every educated child, every strengthened community, and every act of kindness contributed to lasting change. She was deeply committed to creating growth opportunities, ensuring that education and empowerment reached even the most underserved areas. One of her most significant projects was establishing the Takum Community Learning Centre. What started as a small school gradually grew into a multi-purpose institution, offering basic education, vocational training, health outreach, and spiritual mentoring. The centre became a vital resource where children not only received academic instruction but also learned values such as compassion, perseverance, and social responsibility.

Mama Rebecca's leadership extended into public service when she became Zonal Presidential Commissioner in Wukari in 1983. This transition marked the beginning of her direct involvement in governance, where she utilized her skills to influence education and policy. By 1985, she was serving as Councillor for Education in Takum, advocating for improved resources and better access to learning opportunities. Her work gained recognition at the state level, and in 1994, she was appointed Commissioner in the newly created Taraba State. Over the years, she served as the Minister of Rural Development and Cooperatives and the Minister of Agriculture and Natural Resources. Mama Rebecca approached these roles with a commitment to practical, impactful programmes. She worked to empower farmers, promote women's cooperatives, and ensure that government support reached rural communities.

In a predominantly male-dominated space, Mama Rebecca distinguished herself not through authority but through trust and genuine connection with the people she served. She was known for her hands-on approach, conducting field visits, attending late-night planning sessions, and engaging directly with community members. Her advocacy endeared her especially to rural dwellers, particularly women farmers, who saw in her a compassionate leader and a tireless champion for their needs.

Contributions to the Church and Evangelical Work

After retiring from the civil service, Mama Rebecca devoted herself to church ministry. She taught French at Sacred Heart Minor Seminary in Jalingo but gradually focused more on her evangelical work. She became a marriage counselor, a prayer leader, and the first President of the Catholic Women Organization (CWO) in the Jalingo Diocese. Her leadership was marked by her commitment to spiritual growth,

social outreach, and women's empowerment. Mama Rebecca mobilized women to take active roles in church activities, encouraging their participation in liturgical services and community service programmes. She advocated for adult literacy, organized prayer missions, and expanded the CWO's reach, ensuring its impact extended beyond the church walls. Under her leadership, the organization flourished, growing in both numbers and influence. Her collaboration with Sister Catarina Dolci in the orphanage and prison ministry was particularly significant. Whether caring for malnourished children or offering comfort to prisoners, Mama Rebecca approached each act of service with compassion and dedication. She believed that faith should be lived through service, and her work reflected this belief.

One of the most impactful contributions in her later years was the establishment of the Women of Hope Centre in Kona, Jalingo. She dedicated her time and resources to supporting young girls from disadvantaged backgrounds, providing vocational training in tailoring, baking, computing, and entrepreneurship. The centre was more than just a place for skill development; it became a refuge, a space for encouragement, and a pathway to new opportunities. Many of its graduates credited Mama Rebecca for helping them break through poverty and hardship. One former beneficiary said, "She believed in me before I believed in myself."

Challenges and Flaws

From around 2005–2006, Mama Rebecca faced significant health challenges when she suffered a stroke. With medical treatment and therapy, she managed to recover, but her health struggles were far from over. Shortly after, she began experiencing seizures, which progressively affected her speech and movement, making daily life increasingly difficult. Despite these challenges, Mama Rebecca remained spiritually connected, finding solace in gospel songs and Scripture readings. Even as her condition worsened, these moments brought her comfort and strength. Seeking further medical care, she travelled to the United Kingdom with financial support from the late Danbaba Suntai. Unfortunately, doctors confirmed that the seizures had caused irreversible brain damage.

In addition to her declining health, Mama Rebecca endured profound personal losses. She experienced the passing of her husband, Anthony, on August 27, 2007, followed by the deaths of her daughter, Veronica, and grandson, Onyedikachi. These tragedies compounded the difficulties she faced, yet her resilience remained evident. Even when her memory faded and she struggled to recognize familiar faces, Mama Rebecca retained her deep spiritual presence. She could still recite entire passages from the Psalms, and when she sensed someone was troubled, she would instinctively offer words of comfort. Her firm faith and ability to provide solace, even in her most vulnerable state, became a lasting testament to her strength and devotion.

Legacy and Remembrance

As the years passed, Mama Rebecca gradually shifted from active leadership to a

quieter yet profoundly influential role. No longer at the forefront of community projects, she became a respected matriarch whose wisdom was sought by many. Her later years were not a retreat from service but an expansion of her impact, as she became a source of guidance and assurance for those who came to her for counsel. The same community that once watched her work tirelessly in schools, fields, and prayer meetings now gathered at her home to hear her insights on faith, sacrifice, and service.

Mama Rebecca's legacy is rooted in the values she lived by—faith, education, and compassion. She demonstrated that true success is not measured by personal achievements but by the lives touched and transformed through genuine service. Her work continues to inspire, reminding people that unity, kindness, and shared purpose have the power to heal divisions and create lasting change. Her journey is more than a historical account; it is a lasting lesson in perseverance and love. The impact of her service was evident in everyday acts of generosity, the dedication of teachers, and the unwavering belief that a single act of kindness can have a lasting ripple effect across generations. Rebecca's life challenges us to ask how we can serve beyond ourselves and help shape a better world for others.

For those beginning their own paths, her story stands as a call to action. She proved that no effort is too small and no individual too insignificant to make a difference. Her legacy reminds us that when faith, education, and community come together, challenges become surmountable, and hope finds a place in every heart. Through her dogged commitment to service, she left behind not just memories but a lasting blueprint for meaningful change. Mama Rebecca's legacy endures through the stories shared, the lessons learned, and the ideals passed down. Her life was a witness to the power of service, the importance of faith, and the enduring impact of a life lived with purpose. Though she passed on August 23 2007, her influence endures, reminding us that the most significant contributions come not from seeking recognition but from selfless dedication to the well-being of others.

Conclusion

Chronicling the life of Mama Rebecca Hamza serves as a poignant reminder of the timeless truth that a life devoted to faith and service transforms the world. From the quiet early mornings in *Takum* to the expansive legacy of institutions built on the foundation of compassion and education, her journey is a mirror reflecting the infinite capacity of the human spirit to overcome adversity and effect meaningful change. Her story is not confined to the relics of history but continues to offer guidance, inspiration, and a roadmap for personal and communal renewal. Every act of kindness inspired by her legacy, every classroom that opens its doors to learning, every community project aimed at healing, and every moment of shared joy in the face of hardship is a continuation of her story. It is a story that encourages us to take a stand, to give wholeheartedly, and to believe that love and service together can create a better, more inclusive world.

In celebrating the life of Mama Rebecca Hamza, we honour an icon of enduring

light, one who left behind not just memories but a transformative legacy that continues to empower, heal, and inspire. Her story is a guiding star for future generations, a reminder that when one person dares to lead with a heart full of faith and service, the ripple effect can forever change the destiny of a people and, indeed, of the world.

Sources:

Mrs Mary Hamza (Daughter).

Fr. Thaddeus Nwannedirim Onyekineso (Parish Priest) Dr Sir William K. Benedict (Parishioner).

Researcher:

Sr Helena Jummai Ibrahim, OSB.

Life of Mama Elizabeth Ogunlanoh (1922–1986)

Early Life and Education



Mama Elizabeth Ogunlanoh was born on April 24, 1922, in Lagos, Nigeria. She hailed from Benin, Edo State, and was of royal lineage, as her father was a prince of Benin. According to oral tradition, her father fled the palace in pursuit of his Christian faith, specifically Catholicism, and relocated to Lagos. It was there that he met Mama Elizabeth's mother, leading to their marriage and the foundation of their family. As a result, Mama Elizabeth was born into the Catholic faith, which played a significant role in shaping her values and aspirations. As a child, she was curious and

eager to learn. After completing her primary education, she enrolled at St. Carmel in Lagos, a school run by Reverend Sisters whose presence exuded both discipline and grace. Their untiring dedication to knowledge and service left a lasting impression on the young Elizabeth, shaping her aspirations and instilling a deep respect for education. She admired them, their wisdom, their purpose, and the way they guided young minds. Inspired by their teachings, she dreamt of making a contribution to society in the same way.

Determined to fulfill her ambition, Mama Elizabeth pursued a career in teaching. She secured a position at Ibadan Boys' High School, where she quickly became known for her versatility and dedication. She taught with passion, ensuring her students not only absorbed knowledge but felt empowered by it. Her presence in the classroom was magnetic; she was recognized for her resourcefulness and commitment to excellence in teaching.

However, societal norms at the time restricted women's work outside the home, prompting her to resign and focus on her family. Nonetheless, the skills and discipline she had acquired from the Sisters led her to take up sewing, a craft she pursued with utmost passion. Her expertise in sewing earned her local recognition, laying the foundation for her later transition into entrepreneurship in the buying-and-selling business.

Marital and Family Life

Mama Elizabeth was married to Mr Ogunlanoh, an atheist whose personal life was complex. Over the years, he had relationships with multiple women, resulting in many children. Despite this, Mama demonstrated extraordinary kindness and embraced all

of the children as her own, creating a home filled with love and unity. In total, there were around sixteen children under her care, and her devotion was so strong that most of them never realized they did not share the same mother, such was the depth of her nurturing and affection.

Over time, Mama's steadfast faith influenced her husband, and she eventually converted him to the Catholic faith. With his newfound faith, they formalized their marriage in the church, allowing Mama to resume receiving Holy Communion, something deeply significant to her. Her devotion to her faith was firm. Although she had built her own house, she later chose to rent a room near the church to ensure she never missed morning Mass, as the distance from her home made regular attendance difficult. Even in her old age, when attending church was no longer possible, she maintained an altar at home, where she continued to pray and practice her devotions.

One particularly striking event occurred after her husband's passing. A woman who had borne three children for Mr Ogunlanoh surfaced unexpectedly, revealing her relationship with him. Rather than turning away, Mama extended her embrace even further, taking two of the children into her home and raising them with the same care and dedication she had shown the others.

Contributions to the Church and Community

When Mama Elizabeth was appointed "Iya Ijo" (Church Matron), she wholeheartedly embraced the role with all sense of duty and responsibility. Every year, Mama and her bosom friend would contribute funds to purchase a cow for the church's Easter picnic, ensuring a joyous celebration for all. Her home became a familiar gathering place, as many members of her parish would follow her after morning mass to enjoy breakfast in her welcoming space.

Her involvement in the church extended beyond her matronship; she actively participated in numerous church societies, either as a dedicated member or as a matron to many pious societies, providing guidance and support. Mama Elizabeth was fond of often reminding others that *anyone could strive to be a saint* and encouraged those around her to lead lives of faith and integrity. One of the most remarkable aspects of her generosity was her insistence on anonymity. She donated substantial amounts to the church and other causes without seeking recognition. Only those who were close to her were aware of the extent of her charitable giving, and even her children remained largely unaware unless informed by others. She preferred to give quietly, letting her actions speak for themselves.

Beyond financial generosity, Mama Elizabeth was a mentor to many, especially young women. She encouraged those whose husbands did not attend church to bring their children and engage their spouses in conversations about the Catholic faith. Some men embraced the change, while others remained hesitant, but Mama never wavered in her encouragement. Many people continued to gather at her home after Mass, not only for breakfast but for wisdom, warmth, and companionship.

In the broader community, she was regarded as a trusted advisor. Women facing challenges in their marriages or family life often turned to her for guidance, knowing

she would listen with empathy and offer thoughtful solutions. She made it her mission to resolve conflicts, provide comfort, and encourage prayer as a source of strength. Her home was always open, a refuge where anyone in need of support could find solace and reassurance.

Leadership Roles and Virtue of Compassion

Mama Elizabeth was the last *Iya Ijo* (Church Matron) of her parish at the time; the position was still prestigious and not easily attained. Her recognition stemmed from her untiring commitment to the church and her active participation in various societies. She was deeply involved in nearly all church organisations, either as a devoted member or as a guiding matron. Her lifetime dedication extended beyond just membership; she served as a volunteer catechist, always welcoming learners with open arms, regardless of how late they arrived for her catechism class.

One memorable incident, as recalled by her daughter, Mrs Sote, was Mama's kindness and commitment to inclusivity. Testifying to her virtues, Mrs Sote said that some years back, she had hoped and prepared her children to receive the First Holy Communion in the parish where she was attending at the time. However, on the eventful day, due to unavoidable traffic delays, she arrived late and found the doors closed, as instructed by the parish priest. Frustrated and disheartened, she drove to Mama's house, only to observe that her mother was still receiving latecomers into her own catechism class. She generously welcomed the children and others in the same circumstances into the class. This stark contrast in approach deeply affected Mrs Sote to the extent of contemplating leaving the Catholic Church altogether. It was Mama's intervention that persuaded her to reconsider her intention. According to her, "My mother continued to gently remind me that 'if you refuse to work for God, He will raise stones to do the work.'" Mama's wisdom and faith inspired her daughter to remain steadfast, shaping her spiritual journey and devotion to this day.

Beyond her church leadership, Mama was humble, charitable, and deeply accommodating. Though she was known for her generosity, she preferred to give anonymously, avoiding public recognition for her contributions. A devotee of the Sacred Heart of Jesus, the Immaculate Heart of Mary, and St. Anthony of Padua. She lived out her faith in quiet service. Her favourite saying was, "*Always strive to be a saint*," reminding others that holiness was attainable through consistent acts of goodness and faith. Another proverb she often shared was "*A kin wale arugbo lofe*"—a Yoruba saying that translates to "One does not go to an old woman's house freely", which means that every visit should be meaningful, with a purpose or an act of service. Mama encouraged young people to consistently contribute to their elders' lives, ensuring their time was valuable. Mama Elizabeth was also a pillar of compassion and wisdom within her community. One remarkable instance demonstrated her firm stance on the sanctity of life. When an intimate friend's young son impregnated a girl, pressure mounted for the pregnancy to be terminated. Mama strongly opposed the idea, advocating for the child's right to life. She took in the baby at birth, ensuring that the young parents could complete their education without undue hardship. The child,

Mrs Olubunmi Okanlawon, grew up under Mama's care and later recalled her upbringing with deep gratitude.

In her own words, Olubunmi shared, *"I grew up with Mama. I grew up knowing her as my mother. I was told that she took me from my grandmother, who was her bosom friend, because she believed in protecting my life and allowing my parents to complete their schooling. She raised me as her own child, especially since most of her own children had grown and left home. My early years were spent with her, and I never recall any sad moments. She treated me with love, practiced her Catholic faith beautifully, and was a firm yet compassionate disciplinarian."*

Mama Elizabeth's leadership was not defined merely by titles but by the profound impact she left on those around her. She led with kindness, faith, wisdom, and an enduring commitment to nurturing both the church and her community. Her legacy remains one of strength, devotion, and the transformative power of selfless leadership.

Relationship with Priests and Religious Sisters

Mama Elizabeth was known for her exceptional generosity, particularly toward seminarians. During their holidays, her home became a welcoming refuge, a place where they could find warmth and support. She not only provided them with essential provisions but also offered financial assistance, ensuring they were well cared for. Her kindness toward them was constant, and she regarded their presence with deep affection and respect.

Her generosity extended beyond seminarians to the priests and religious sisters as well. She frequently prepared meals and personally delivered them, a gesture that reflected both her hospitality and her commitment to the church. Her home was always open to members of the clergy, and they, in turn, found comfort in her friendship. Whether through acts of kindness or simple companionship, Mama Elizabeth cultivated a strong, lasting bond with religious figures, making them feel genuinely valued and welcome in her presence.

Challenges and Flaws

Like everyone, Mama Elizabeth Ogunlanoh had imperfections. Her firmness and strong sense of discipline were qualities that shaped her character and leadership. While many appreciated her strong principles and structured approach, others found it difficult to accept. She held high expectations for those around her and had little tolerance for irresponsibility or misconduct. Her strict demeanor, though rooted in good intentions, could sometimes be perceived as too rigid. Nevertheless, her discipline was a cornerstone of her success, guiding both her family and community with a sense of order and purpose.

Legacy and Remembrance

Mama Elizabeth was the embodiment of love and compassion, extending her kindness

not only to her own children but to everyone around her. She treated all with warmth and equality, creating an atmosphere of acceptance and care. Mrs Olubunmi fondly recalled how Mama fiercely protected her from any harm, refusing to tolerate mistreatment, even from her own biological son. Yet, despite her protective nature, Mama never hesitated to discipline when necessary, instilling in those under her care the values of respect and responsibility. Her unending kindness made her beloved by all who knew her.

One of the most touching stories surrounding Mama's final days was her vision of an *invisible garden of roses*. As she approached the end of her life, she would tell her daughter to pick roses from this mystical garden, the garden only she could see. Deeply moved by this experience, her daughter later planted a rose garden in her memory, ensuring that Mama's presence and spirit lived on in a beautiful, tangible form.

In a profound testament to her faith, Mama passed away just seconds after receiving Holy Communion, marking her departure in a moment of deep spiritual connection. She breathed her last in 1986, leaving behind a legacy of humility, generosity, unshakable faith, and steadfast love for God. Those who still remember her do so with admiration, cherishing her as a giver, a mentor, and a guiding light in their lives. Her legacy is adorned with the many laurels she earned—not just in recognition but in the lives she touched and the faith she so passionately upheld.

Sources:

Mrs Sote (Daughter).

Mr Anthony Emmanuel Ogunyale (Parishioner), Mrs Olubunmi Okanlawon (Adopted Daughter).

Researchers:

Late Rev. Fr. Dr Anthony Oyedamola Akiwowo and Mrs Yetunde Anne Akerele.

On Writing the Biographies of African Christian Ancestors: Theology, Memory, and the Power of Story⁵⁵

By Stan Chu Ilo

“What will the study of Christianity look like if scholars put women at the centre of their research?” ~Dana Robert

“We must discover the oral dimension of theology, which is no less important than the Summae and the great treatises. Christian theology must be liberated from a cultural system that sometimes gives the false impression that the Word has been reduced to text. Why can't the language of faith also portray song, game, art, dance, and above all, the gesture of humanity standing up and marching wherever the Gospel elicits and nourishes a liberating effort.” ~Jean Marc Ela⁵⁶

Introduction

There is a story about a missionary who went to a remote area of Tanzania to proclaim the Gospel among the Maasai, an ethnic group known for its fierce warriors. One day, the missionary was telling a group of adults about the saving work of Jesus Christ. He explained that Jesus is the Son of God, the Saviour, and Redeemer of all humankind. When the missionary ended his story, a Maasai elder slowly stood up and said, “You have spoken well, but I want to learn more about what made this person great. I have three questions about him. First, did he ever kill a lion? Second, how many cows did he have? Third, how many wives and children did he have?”⁵⁷ For the Maasai, a man's greatness is measured in how many cows he owns, how many wives and children he has, and how many lions he has killed in his efforts to protect his livestock. One must therefore raise a preliminary question about the role of language in communicating the Christian message and the genre of theological reflection in Africa. How are African local cultural idioms, communication media, and literature employed to convey different layers of meaning to diverse communities of faith and cultures in Africa and world Christianity? How are Africans telling the stories of God's wondrous deeds on the continent through African theology, and what role does African literature play in this?

⁵⁵ This essay was initially published as the Introduction to the volume *Unsung Heroes of Faith: Outstanding Catholic Women in Nigeria*, vol. 1, edited by Sr. Dr. Elizabeth Titilayo Aduloju, SSMA (African Catholic Press [AfriCaP], Catholic Diocesan Secretariate Complex, 3rd Floor, off Nnobi Road, Nnewi, Anambra State, Nigeria).

⁵⁶ Jean-Marc Ela, *African Cry* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis Books, 1986), 49-50.

⁵⁷ Story taken from Joseph G. Healey, *African Stories for Preachers and Teachers* (Nairobi, Kenya: Paulines Publications, 2014), 33.

African Christian faith is primarily mediated through African languages, patterns, and models of discourse, liturgical life, and ritual performance. Africa's social context shapes it. Through these communication channels, African Christianity has distinctive features. It is becoming a strong partner with the rest of Christianity through rich intercultural exchanges and commonalities in the Christian life, which define the present cultural momentum in world Christianity.

However, as in the story of the Maasai and the missionary, African theologies constantly struggle to find their own voices in world Christianity. They have sometimes not kept pace with the faith and local processes in African Christian communities and churches. Conscious of this challenge, African theologians are gradually moving toward greater adoption of Africa's unique language of discourse in their theological methods. In accounting for the great deeds of God and the strong growth of the Christian population in Africa, one needs to adopt a medium of communication capable of conveying the people's message to the world. This includes producing theological works that are portraits of the actual faith of our ancestors as the footprints of God in our history. How to tell the stories of the African past is the focus of this introduction, or, as Kwame Bediako put it, what was God doing in the African past before the missionaries?⁵⁸ This introductory essay develops the answer to that question. It introduces the groundbreaking work of the writers and promoters of the Dictionary of African Christian Biography, who have written biographies of African women of faith in this volume and subsequent volumes.

African Christian churches are a growing influence on the continent in many areas. These include education, healthcare ministries, outreach to people experiencing poverty, peace and reconciliation in communities and among nations, and social transformation. The churches' influence is reflected in the stories of Christian witnessing and proclamation, which emerge from individual and communal experience as they reflect on their faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. The ways these stories are presented by African theologians, and through which media, offer greater accountability for making the Christian faith intelligible to God's people in Africa in its nature, features, manifestations, and relevance. In doing this, African theologians are producing new literature in different genres, and their theological productions are also influenced, inspired, and nourished by African literature and oratory.

The word 'literature' to describe theological reflection in Africa, or as a source and channel of theological production, may be restrictive in considering theological development in Africa. Like the Maasai experience narrated at the beginning of this chapter, one must be conscious of one's discourse language and whether it conveys adequate meaning to one's audience. In this chapter, I adopt a different path in giving an account of theology and literature in Africa, because African literature is like and unlike literature elsewhere.

To begin with, we should distinguish between formal academic theology and the informal and diffuse theological productions of Africa. Professional theologians

⁵⁸ Andrew Walls, *The Missionary Movement from the West: A Biography from Birth to Old Age*, ed. Brian Stanley (Grand Rapids, Maryland: Eerdmans, 2023), 229.

undertake formal theological writings in Africa.⁵⁹ The informal and diffuse theologies in Africa are commonplace today through leaflets, homilies (including open preaching on the streets and at revival and faith healing ceremonies), songs, prayers, billboards, radio and television announcements, testimonies at worship centres and in liturgical gatherings, fundraising publicity, notices sent through social media (especially WhatsApp, Facebook, and Instagram), automated voice messages, and prayers and blessings sent to people's phones by founders of churches and their prayer warriors and minstrels. These informal channels have become the most significant and influential media for proclaiming the Word of God, interpreting the faith and its relevance to the daily lives of people in Africa, and giving an account of the movement of history in Africa in light of the Christian faith.⁶⁰ The momentum of Christian expansion in Africa and the narratives driving the faith on the continent are more closely tied to these informal literary efforts and theologies than to the writings of Africa's professional theologians.

The Bible in African Christian Religion: Hearing the Word

Many informal channels for theological education and communication exist today in Africa, especially through the Bible. One of the significant findings of the 'Bible in Africa Project' of 1991–94 is the striking relationship between African reading of the Bible, performance of biblical texts in worship, and the formation of African Christian consciousness.⁶¹ The Bible remains Africa's most important and widely circulated Christian literature. Lamin Sanneh, Kwame Bediako, Justin Ukpong, and Andrew Walls are some of the scholars who have studied the effects of Bible translation on the successful transmission of Christianity in Africa, in both the Western missionary and post-Western missionary eras. Philip Jenkins reports on the Bible in Africa: "Today, at least one Book of the Bible is available for approximately 650 of Africa's 2,000 languages, and 150 languages have complete Bibles. And a translated Bible defies conventional images of missionary imperialism. Once the Bible is translated into the vernacular, it becomes the people's property."

Why has the Bible become so popular in Africa? Through my pastoral work, social ministry, research, and ethnographic study, I have identified five reasons why the

⁵⁹ Agbonkhanmeghe Orobator, *Theology Brewed in an African Pot* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 2008), ix.

⁶⁰ For instance, see Paul Gifford's account of two Pentecostal churches in Nigeria, the 'Mountain of Fire and Miracles Ministries' and 'The Living Faith Church Worldwide,' and their use of literature (books, Internet, leaflets), anointing oil, and other symbols to communicate the power of God, or what Gifford calls "enchanted Christianity." See Paul Gifford, *Christianity, Development and Modernity in Africa* (London: Hurst and Company, 2015), 29–44.

⁶¹ Justin S. Ukpong, "Popular Readings of the Bible in Africa and Implications for Academic Readings: Report on the Field Research Carried out on Oral Interpretation of the Bible in Port Harcourt Metropolis, Nigeria under the Auspices of the Bible in Africa Project, 1991–1994," in *The Bible in Africa: Transactions, Trajectories and Trends*, ed. Gerald O. West and Musa Dube (Boston: Brill, 2001), 582–94.

Bible is the most essential Christian literature in Africa today. First, the messages spread quickly among Africans because the Bible has been translated into indigenous languages. Africans are attracted to the Word of life when they hear it in their own languages and profess it in their mother tongues. Second, the biblical words and images capture the imagination of Africans because the stories—especially from the OT, the Gospels, and Acts—have parallels within Africa's own cultural, religious, and spiritual imagination and rituals. The third concerns the narrative techniques employed in the biblical accounts, including parables, metaphors, stories, genealogies, hagiographies, biographies, and communal experience. These appeal to the natural world as sites for divine encounters and channels for the miraculous and sublime, such as mountains, trees, rivers, vegetation, streams, and animals. These are also readily applied to Africa's own religious experience, grammar of assent, and plausibility structure. Fourth is the use of memory for the transmission and retention of the biblical texts, which leverages most African traditional societies' own memorial culture and orality.

The fifth is the most critical factor concerning the Bible and the momentum of Christian expansion in Africa, beyond the inner power of the Word as inspired by the Holy Spirit. As Jenkins points out, this factor is "biblical ideas and texts spread by the methods appropriate to oral cultures."⁶² Most African Christians still receive the Word of God not as a written text, but as a proclaimed Word mediated through preaching, songs, and liturgical dance. The missionary mandate to "go and proclaim the good news" (Matthew 28:19) emphasizes oral communication and transmission. This is still the primary way to share the Word of God in Africa. Hearing the Word orally for non-literate respondents (interviewed in the 'Bible in Africa' research) often produced greater passion and purpose in their faith journey than reading the biblical text. Oral communication was seen as having a direct and immediate pneumatic effect, relating to the spiritual power of God's Word conveyed and received through hearing, interpretation, and performance. Hearing the Word of God inspires people to pray, praise, offer spiritual and ethical responses, and respond practically and immediately to God, who is called in most African churches. How this Word operates in the lives of Christians to bring about faith and its fruits is essential to theology.

The Word is powerful not because it was written, but because the Word moved Africans, received through proclamation, preaching, performance, and ritualization in Christian worship and daily life. Researchers note the importance of the spoken Word in African culture and its integral role in Africans' direct connection to the Word of God, as well as its power to bless or curse. The revealed Word is powerful not because it is written, but because it is heard, performed, and lived. Oral communication is valid in the Church as a form of witnessing because it is the aesthetics of action, which is credible because of its evidential import in performance.

I must add a cautionary note here regarding Bible reading. Many years ago, Aylward Shorter and Joseph Njiru, in their work on new religious movements, warned of the challenges posed by self-ordained street (and *matatu*) preachers who, without

⁶² Jenkins, *The New Faces of Christianity*, 27.

any formal training, proclaim the Word “in ridding the world of all oppressions of the devil.”⁶³ This is an essential observation for understanding the changing dynamics of Christianity in Africa and the shifting nature of religious authority there. Attention must be paid to how the biblical text is applied to people’s lives and to their suffering, without any critical understanding of the text, the nature of the suffering they face, or their location. This is an essential concern that we cannot address comprehensively in this chapter, but it warrants further discussion and research.

Hearing God’s Word through the Words of Men and Women

As a doctoral student fourteen years ago, an encounter with a professor motivated my interest in the place of oral communication in the writing of African Christian history. A fellow African student was bright and active in class discussions. However, he received low grades whenever he wrote an essay for the course. He invited me to accompany him as a witness when he met with the professor to find out why he wasn’t getting the grades he thought he deserved. This was a course on the work of a Western theologian, to which my coursemate had devoted much time and energy. When we met with the professor, he explained to my friend that he was doing well in class discussions because he came from an oral and memorial culture. According to this professor, when it came to writing, my classmate was not adequately communicating his thoughts because of his limitations in translating his verbal discourse into text. My friend was furious with the professor for what he thought was a racist comment, and I remember having to calm him down.

Without going into the details of what happened subsequently, this began my pursuit of what ‘memorial culture’ and ‘oral culture’ meant for me as an African and whether what this professor said was true. I first sought to understand what memorial culture meant in the classical world—especially Greek, Hebrew, and Roman traditions—and African societies. This led me to study Aristotle’s analysis of language and communication in his *Rhetoric*, Plato’s *Meno* and *Phaedrus*, and Augustine’s rich writings on memory and semiotics, especially in *On Christian Doctrine*, *The Teacher*, and *Confessions*. For my doctoral thesis, I undertook an ethnographic study, collecting information conveyed through oral culture, focusing on African ancestral traditions. At the same time, I took an additional specialization course in African studies, concentrating on the transmission of African cultural knowledge, artifacts, and symbols, and their retention as collective memory in oral forms.

What struck me most was that, in most classical cultures, the development of literary traditions and the documentation of history through writing did not diminish the role of memory. Neither was rhetoric restricted to literacy and textuality. Instead, speech and memory were richly diverse and performative, serving as intentional modes

⁶³ Aylward Shorter and Joseph Njiru, *New Religious Movements in Africa* (Nairobi: Paulines Publications Africa, 2001), 40.

for communicating meaning, history, and knowledge beyond what is documented in a text. While a discourse or narrative may be rendered in proper grammar and conventional textual forms, what is understood in communication to an audience or receptor traditions can have a life of its own and convey richer meaning and truth beyond what is housed in any literary form.

This personal realization inspired me to explore how oral communication works among Africans, whether the claim that orality is a handmaid of memory is valid, and whether memory is housed in orality before and beyond its literary form. This led me to ask, what is the relationship between orality and memory in writing the biographies of individual Christians? How does the writing of the biography of a particular African Christian become a ‘genuine’ effort at writing African Christian history? A preliminary conclusion, among others, is that preventing historical erasures or the loss of cultural memory in African Christianity is one of the significant outcomes of a project I have been associated with since 2014, the ‘Dictionary of African Christian Biography’ (DACB). This project has been concurrent with the development of writing African history through African literature, which began vigorously with the emergence, since the 1950s, of African novels, poems, and anthologies of stories and proverbs by African authors.

Two more personal aspects also led me to dig into the world of oral traditions in Africa to understand the African religious past before the advent of Western missionaries. The first is that I did not know my grandparents. My grandfather died during the Civil War in Nigeria (1967–70) before I was born. My grandmother did not convert to Christianity and was never comfortable sharing our tribal history with us or stories of our ancestors. The history of my ancestry does not go beyond what my parents told me and what I learned from the elders of the Achi clan in Eastern Nigeria. Thus, I have limited access to my ancestors’ collective memory. This is also true of Christian history in my part of the world. The Christian history I knew before beginning serious personal research into the roots of my African Christian faith, while studying in Europe and North America, was the history of what Catholic missionaries did in Igbo land. This includes the heroism and courage of Bishop Shanahan, Father Fox, and Bishop Charles Heerey. If stories are essential to convey the meaning of the past, and if, as Walter Benjamin argues, memory is not only the instrument for exploring the past but also “a medium for the past,” it is a formidable challenge for me to tell the story of my people and their faith journey as Christians when I have limited access to this memory.⁶⁴ This is a fundamental challenge for me and one that any modern theologian in Africa faces.

The challenge is complex because the Northern epistemological privilege given to mainstream education in African Christian schools consciously promoted a whitewashed historical account of Christianity. It presented Christianity as endogenous to cultural and civilizational currents in the West. Religious history and stories of the

⁶⁴ See Walter Benjamin, “Excavation and Memory,” in *Selected Writings* Volume 2, 1927–1934, trans. Rodney Livingstone and others, ed. Michael W. Jennings, Howard Eiland, and Gary Smith (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1999), 576.

sacred in Africa before the arrival of Western missionaries were either presented as negative or passed over in silence. Our ancestors—such as our grandparents and great-grandparents who had some traces of this memory—were either dead by the time we were born in post-colonial Africa or were swept away by the cultural currents. These currents were already redefining the canons of history, the map of the universe, and the limits and boundaries of what should be considered practical knowledge or negative history. The tales of the grannies in Africa from the rich memories of their African spiritual heritage, Christian and traditional, were then seen not as narratives of belonging for the construction and reconstruction of being and meaning in Africa. Instead, they were merely celebrations of some historical relics to feed the fancies of young Africans and show them ‘how it used to be.’ Folktales, proverbs, legends, myths of origin, religious history, and African spiritual traditions were not presented to us as sources of validation for our beliefs or for meeting the exigencies of present history. Instead, they were served to us young Africans as a scattered patchwork of the past to be kept as the past, since they belong to negative, bypassed, and uncivilized notions of God, life, the world, society, and the cosmos.

Likewise, the essential contributions of Africans were not presented to us either at home or in the schools and churches. I am thinking of the work of Mojola Akpebi, Ajayi Crowther, Wade Harris, Chief Onyeama na Eke, and Edward Blyden. Also, some powerful narratives of African women founders of churches, such as Paolina Dlamini (1858–1942), Abiodun Akinsowan (1907–94), Christina Nku (1894–1980), and many women who led the East African revival Balokole movement and faith-based women-led groups to the Christian mission in Africa. These people all contributed to the success of the modern Christian mission on the continent.⁶⁵ Musa W. Dube’s essay, “God Never Opened the Bible to Me’: Women Church Leaders in Botswana,” presents a compelling account of why the story of Christianity should be told through a womanist perspective.

Most importantly, basing her research on ethnographic studies and the writings of important African theologians like Mercy Amba Oduyoye and Isabel Phiri, she demonstrates the critical role of African women in shaping the past and current history and shape of Christianity in Africa. Among many other illuminating points she makes, her account shows that women “have always found ways that subvert the structural exclusion that marginalizes them from power in society. They have found ways to create and operate in another space, outside the boundaries and by the margins of both written history and culture.”⁶⁶ Post-colonial and post-Vatican II young African theologians like me continue to search for the roots of present African Christian history beyond the normative reading of accounts of Western missionary activities in Africa and their successful or limited outcomes. We must look not only at the predominant male accounts that dominate African Church history, but also at sources on women’s

⁶⁵ Leanne Dzubinski and Anneke Stasson, *Women in the Mission of the Church: Their Opportunities and Obstacles throughout Christian History* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2021), 191–97.

⁶⁶ Musa Dube, “‘God Never Opened the Bible to Me’: Women Church Leaders in Botswana.” *Studies in World Christianity and Interreligious Relations* 48 (2014), 318.

contributions to the Church in Africa that exist “outside the boundaries of written history in church and in general.”⁶⁷

According to Michele Sigg, the *Dictionary of African Christian Biography* (DACB) was designed to retrieve the strands of African Christian history that were disappearing by harvesting and documenting “the biographies of ‘the major creative and innovative local figures more vitally involved’—a history that is ‘virtually absent from the standard scholarly reference works.’ Born out of a deep respect for the ancient history of African Christianity and its astounding contemporary vitality, the goal of the DACB is to serve as a sort of ‘gallery of saints’ that provides the insight and perspective of Africans into their own Christian history. Here, the intended meaning of the term ‘saint’ is that used by Paul in his greeting to the Romans: ‘to all God’s beloved in Rome, who are called to be saints’ (Rom. 1:7).”⁶⁸ The DACB is, therefore, an answer to the search by many Africans like me to hear the stories of the Christian enterprise in Africa, told through the lives of African Christians, using African methods, and through the voices of Africans themselves. These narratives have been enriched by the contributions of many non-Africans who are convinced that world Christian history is incomplete if it does not respect, acknowledge, and mine the rich contributions of Africans and Africa. This extends to the realities of our times and moving into the future.

I want to focus on three critical points in the rest of the chapter regarding the significance of DACB as a source of African missional theology. The first is examining the importance of narrative and biography in writing African Christian history. I will look at the writing of African Christian history through biographies as a subset of the development of the African literary tradition of storytelling and oral communication as a communal event. Second, I will consider the importance of biography as a narrative of the actual faith of African Christians, which is central to the mission of God in Africa and to writing lived African theology. I will highlight why it is important to include stories of everyone, especially women and the non-ordained, in telling God’s marvelous deeds among us. I will develop this through a biblical-theological analysis of the principles at work in the collection and formation of the biblical canons. Finally, while focusing on the ‘how’ of the development of biblical canons from oral to written tradition, I will describe appropriate methods for collecting biographical data on our African Christian ancestors and explain why this is an African missional theology.

The Importance of Narrative in Writing African Christian History

At the beginning of the New Millennium, Pope John Paul II appealed to local churches to identify and celebrate their own local witnesses of the faith. He is reputed to be the pope who canonized more saints than all his predecessors put together. The invitation

⁶⁷ Musa Dube, “‘God Never Opened the Bible to Me’: Women Church Leaders in Botswana.”, 318.

⁶⁸ Michele Miller Sigg, “The Dictionary of African Christian Biography and the Story of Ethiopian Christianity, *International Bulletin of Missionary Research* (October 2015), vol. 39, no. 4, 204.

by John Paul to local churches to celebrate their own saints,⁶⁹ from a Catholic perspective, stimulated a more conscious effort to recognize the men and women in their local history who lived the Gospel values fully. Local Christian communities were encouraged to identify among their own people those men and women who modeled in their lives the priorities and practices of the Lord Jesus Christ. It was an invitation to enter the stories of the heroic witnesses to the power of God's grace in our ecclesial bodies.

For me, it is the most significant shift in Catholicism's recognition of African Christianity. If this continent, through its appropriation of specific African Christian traditions, could raise these heroes of faith, then the experience of faith and life in African Christian communities could be proposed as a valid medium for encountering Christ. This is because it could form men and women who embody the virtues and values that reflect the Lord Jesus's priorities and practices. When this is viewed against the backdrop of the negative framing of African Christianity in some past and current writings, one can see the significance of this inculturation of saint-making in Catholicism.

The DACB, while not a hagiographic collection or documentation of African saints, is a strong testament to the depth and strength of African Christianity. This is shown through the stories of the men and women who have borne witness to God, Church, society, and their local communities in fidelity to the message of the Gospel. The DACB is an African Christian ancestral project. This is because it inculturates an African ancestral model by situating the words and deeds of these African Christian witnesses within the continuity of Christian witnessing, analogous to the ongoing account of the Acts of the Apostles. The DACB is an act of the new apostles of the Lord, transmitting the mighty works of God in Africa and from Africa to the rest of the world through the biographies of African witnesses to the faith. These stories reveal God's footprints in African history. They also challenge us to model ourselves after the examples of these African Christians and to work hard in our own times, using the resources available to us, to build on what they have done and to draw inspiration from the Holy Spirit. The DACB opens new roads to writing African Christian history. The essential point is communication through narration of the love of God and God's mighty deeds in Africa.

The importance of this beautiful task is evident in the challenges involved in documenting African history more broadly. But how has history been reported in Africa, primarily through literature, of which the DACB is a subset, albeit sacred? In his famous 1998 address at the McMillan-Stewart Lectures at Harvard University, the late foremost African novelist Chinua Achebe spoke of the balance of stories in writing about Africa (this was the address that inspired the now more famous TEDx presentation by Nigerian novelist Chimamanda Adichie on the danger of a single

⁶⁹ John Paul II, *Tertio Millennio Adveniente*, apostolic letter, November 10, 1994, https://www.vatican.va/content/john-paul-ii/en/apost_letters/1994/documents/hf_jp-ii_apl_19941110_tertio-millennio-adveniente.html, sec. 37.

story).⁷⁰ Achebe wrote that those who never learned how to write their own story will be condemned to live the story and images of themselves created by others. However, he also looked toward a new world where we can see each other's stories as interconnected:

It is not true that my history is only in my heart; it is indeed there, but it is also in that dusty road in my town and in every villager, living and dead, who has ever walked on it. It is in my country too; in my continent, and, yes, in the world. That dusty little road is my link to all the other destinations. To ask everybody to shut down their history, pack their bags, and buy a one-way ticket to Europe or America is just crazy, in my view.⁷¹

In my encounters with fellow Africans and non-Africans, I am increasingly convinced that the African continent is burdened by what V. Y. Mudimbe calls the “invention of Africa.”⁷² It does not matter whether this image is negative, positive, or a little in between. The importance is in examining what one ever knew about Africa and refining one's insight based on new information or reinterpretation of that story when it is proven to be inadequate and biased. This underlies the need to dig beyond generalizations and stereotypes, real or imagined.

My approach to African studies is a ‘total picture’ method. Any aspect of African history and the African condition reveals significant and essential insights about Africa as a whole, such that each challenge or facet of African history can be understood only in the light of the whole of African reality. I read African history seeking intersections, connections, and hidden treasures in ordinary and extraordinary social experiences and the cross-cultural and intercultural forces. Some rich dimensions in the narrative of Africa can be found in entering the high cultural context and the noetic value of African history. This approach pays humble attention to internal and external cultural forces, the diversity within particular elements, and the local instantiation of the so-called African predicament. Every aspect of African reality can and should be viewed and understood from any aspect of African reality. A story of one African Christian sheds light on other aspects of African history and the path to any genuine search for the footprints of God in Africa.

There is no place where this “invention of Africa” plays out more prominently than in the present narratives of the Christian religion and its peregrinations on the continent. Such hackneyed phrases as ‘Africa as the new homeland of Christ,’ ‘Africa as the heartland of Christianity,’ ‘Africans as incurably religious,’ ‘African notions of God,’ and ‘Africa as a continent of *Ubuntu* and *Sankofa*’ are rarely critiqued by Africans themselves. Sometimes, when those outside the continent question these claims, they are not often received with openness to dialogue. These heavy categories, with their

⁷⁰ Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, “The danger of a single story,” July 2009, TED talk, https://www.ted.com/talks/chimamanda_ngozi_adichie_the_danger_of_a_single_story.

⁷¹ Chinua Achebe, *Home and Exile* (Edinburgh: Canongate, 2003), 91.

⁷² V. Y. Mudimbe, *The Invention of Africa: Gnosis, Philosophy, and the Order of Knowledge* (Bloomington, IN: Indiana University Press, 1988).

meanings and interpretations among many, continue to define and redefine how many see the movement of the Spirit in African Christian history. Severe social, economic, theological, cultural, or political challenges facing Africa are often overlooked. This works against the voices and ingenuity of local processes midwived through local communities, local knowledge, and local memory and performances. In many instances, some African scholars are not sufficiently self-critical about the traditions and cultural traces that remain, and the new roads that present historical challenges and complexities are open to engagement, interpretation, judgment, and evaluation of African Christianity.

As Godfrey Brown notes:

History may be a matter of words and shards, carefully preserved in libraries and museums across Europe; in Africa, it is a living environment. Indeed, the shortage of written documentation is likely to be characteristic of some areas of African history, a curse for the historian but a blessing for the history teacher.⁷³

The biography of an African Christian opens the living environment of faith from which the individual grew. It also sheds new light on the environment of faith and new and unexplored roads that believers can follow by paying attention to the life of the ancestor whose story is being collected. Ogbu Kalu argues that African history:

It is a means of transmitting and preserving culture, an instrument for organizing and interpreting collective and individual experiences to provide understanding of the present and a guide for the future. It was a means of providing political education and leadership elites...It served to promote understanding and respect for the community's institutions and practices. The court historians combined oratory with historical expertise.⁷⁴

Kalu draws attention to three contending models in writing African Christian history: institutional, missionary, and native agents.

I will highlight the institutional model here. The institutional approach assumes that church history begins only with the arrival of a missionary: "From that point, church history reconstructs the vertical and horizontal growths of the institution, the pattern of responses, and the impact of the change agent on the community."⁷⁵

Among other problems, this approach ignores the spiritual heritage of particular faith contexts and, at times, neglects or demonizes the local process of translating the faith. As Kalu argues forcefully, when African Christianity idealizes the Church as the bearer of salvation, it creates a dichotomy between the people and the Church as an institution. Furthermore, African institutional history tends to promote

⁷³ Godfrey N. Brown, "The Place of African History in Education in Africa," in *Africa in the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries*, ed. Joseph C. Anene and Godfrey Brown (Ibadan, Nigeria: University of Ibadan Press, 1967), 7.

⁷⁴ Ogbu Kalu, "Introduction: The Shape and Flow of African Church Historiography," in *African Christianity: An African Story*, ed. Ogbu Kalu (Trenton, NJ: African World Press, 2007), 11.

⁷⁵ Kalu, "Introduction," 12.

denominationalism, as African Christians are forced to see themselves not as African Christians but as “products of warring confessional groups” in the West.⁷⁶ As Kalu proposes, when it comes to writing Christian history, “church history is about the understanding of God’s activity among the poor and their responses to the kingdom’s presence in their midst. It is a people’s history of their perception of God’s saving grace amid their struggles for survival.”⁷⁷

Today’s World Christianity teaches us that, unlike in the past, when Christianity identified itself with cultural, political, and economic privilege, domination, and influence, the mission of God today calls us to move away from the desire to preserve the earthly dominion that threatens to empty the Gospel of its truth and force. It also calls for exploring the rich possibilities of developing a humble and expansive theological engagement, which can birth intercultural and theological border crossings in the beauty, diversity, and cultural pluralism of World Christianity.

This new approach challenges theologians to a more comprehensive and diffuse narrative, leveraging multiple voices on where God works in the Church and history, beyond the dominant, restrictive Western account. As Andrew Walls wrote, “African Christian history is...distorted by attempts to make it an appendage of a ‘general’ church history, which is a form of European clan history.”⁷⁸ This approach to writing African Christian history through biographies transgresses the universalizing dominance of historical canons, which often have marginalized the voices of minorities; it also challenges the essentialized sociological form of institutional Catholicism, which usually hampers the flourishing of the charisms of individuals and the growth of local churches and cultures in diverse contexts of faith and life. It calls for an open-structured empirical approach that privileges the narrative of living-faith-in-action of ordinary everyday Christians at the multiple frontiers of proclamation, witnessing, martyrdom, worship, and service. In this regard, one cannot claim that there is an original Christianity by which other forms will be judged. Nor can one claim that there is a traditional language of Christianity or give preference to any particular historical form in which Christianity has appeared as an ideal model that has to be retained, reformed, restored, and replicated everywhere. Attempts to absolutize particular cultural mediations of the faith are either cultural romanticism or cultural idolatry, both of which threaten the ever-renewing impulse of the Gospel to speak from within and beyond human culture. In addition, one cannot insist on a transcendental ecclesiology or an ecclesiological archetype that must be replicated, root, stock, and branches, from Rome to the margins.

The point being made here, in agreement with Kalu, is that the African historiography pioneered by the DACB, for instance, draws from sources other than “the traditional documentary and archival sources that may be available only in colonial

⁷⁶ Kalu, “Introduction,” 13.

⁷⁷ Kalu, “Introduction,” 14.

⁷⁸ Andrew Walls, “Eusebius Tries Again” in *Enlarging the Story: Perspectives on Writing World Christian History*, ed. Wilbert Shenk (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2002), 11.

or missionary repositories in the West.”⁷⁹ These new accounts of history show that reform is taking place in World Christianity outside the West, beyond institutional privileges and power in many little places. Indeed, the DACB collects the stories of many unsung heroes of the Christian mission in Africa. This approach is a reformation or detraditionalizing of the writing of Christian history in Africa. Alan Anderson, for instance, has called African Pentecostalism a new reformation.⁸⁰ Some of these reforms are taking place in everyday African Christians’ lives without receiving much attention because they are happening at the margins, the new frontiers of faith. Some of the signs of reform identified by Lamin Sanneh include: the ecumenical, cross-cultural, and inter-cultural nature of Christian expansion in many societies in the Global South; the variety and diversity of its expressions; the structural and anti-structural nature of the changes taking place in organization, worship, and social engagements; the familiar and non-familiar manifestations of spiritual experiences among new Christians in these areas; the broad spectrum of theological views and ecclesiastical traditions represented; the diffuse and inclusive nature and style of authority and leadership; and the process of acute indigenization that fosters liturgical renewal, the production of religious art, music, hymns, songs, and prayers, which has given Christianity in the non-Western world a stunningly diverse and changing profile.⁸¹ These cultural processes and the “modern-day indigenous formative process” in the Global South, Sanneh argues, may not fit into established canons of orthodoxy or canon law in the institutional narrative of Catholicism. As a result, they are not accounted for in the old historiography of Christianity or in Church history, which remains dominant globally. Lamin Sanneh invites scholars to “break out of their preoccupation with the European heartland and its structures of power and look to the frontier, scarce in institutional assets but with a teeming diversity that attests to the religion’s genius for fostering a spirit of unity along with a variety of styles and idioms.”⁸²

When this shift in thinking and writing of African Christian history occurs, African theologies emerge as the anti-structural and unofficial renewal of the Church, as in the Christian witness, spirituality, and ethics of the great movements in Christian history, such as the rise of monasticism in Egypt.⁸³ While the Church needs institutional structures to ritualize practices of any kind, the history of our Church and society has repeatedly shown that institutional authorization or approval is driven mainly by the protection of institutional privilege and power. This is why a central impulse of reform today from the margins concerns how the movement of the Spirit in history could proceed in the direction of the eschatological fulfillment of the mission of God, enabled

⁷⁹ Michele Miller Sigg, “The Dictionary of African Christian Biography and the Story of Ethiopian Christianity,” *International Bulletin of Missionary Research*, 206.

⁸⁰ Allan Richardson, *An Introduction to Pentecostalism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 104.

⁸¹ Lamin Sanneh, *Disciples of All Nations: Pillars of World Christianity*. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), XIX.

⁸² Sanneh, *Disciples of all Nations: Pillars of World Christianity*, 55.

⁸³ Lamin Sanneh, *Disciples of All Nations: Pillars of World Christianity*, 55.

by these institutions and not predicated on institutional predilections that may not always correspond with the overall goal of the reign of God. It is also why it is essential to write African theology from an ancestral perspective, excavating rich oral narratives and eyewitness accounts of the great deeds of God in Africa and the mission of God in African Christian history that may be forgotten in African Church history.⁸⁴

The DACB attempts to reverse this institutional priority in writing African history. This is more in line with the NT model, where everyone, especially the poor and the weak, is not only invited to God's kingdom and belongs entirely to the family of God as God's own people, but also plays a part in telling the stories of God's great works in history. Werner H. Kelber asserts that in the formation of the NT written traditions, the oral transmission flourished in the early Church beyond the textual. The early Christians lived a rootless life and embraced the ethical radicalism of poverty and homelessness. They were often persecuted, lived on the margins of society, and led a migratory existence. Their particular social identification differed from the mainstream religious traditions around them. The early Church embraced the message Jesus proclaimed. The Lord's message was received orally. They believed in the Word of life, not the Book of life. They treasured the saving, liberating, and healing message of the Gospel proclaimed by the Lord, which resonated profoundly with their daily lives; the oral proclamation was retained not in text but through the concrete, breathing life of the community.⁸⁵

The importance of orality and storytelling in Africa has been emphasized in African scholarship, especially in the development of African literature and orature. In terms of African history in African literature, Abiola Irele argues:

The dominance of orality in the cultural environment of African expression seemed to offer possibilities for validating the endeavour to state the relevance of orality not only to a general understanding of the processes involved in human communication but also, and in particular, to formulate an all-encompassing idea of imaginative expression, one that would point toward a universal concept of literature.⁸⁶

Irele's perspective reinforces Kalu and Brown's contention that oral tradition cannot be dismissed in Africa. Rather, oral tradition continues to flourish in Africa because of its high cultural, collectivist, and communal context, which furnishes what Irele calls "a more flexible principle of textuality" and an impermanence of text with "a built-in principle of instability."⁸⁷

Oral or written text is embedded in memory as forms of "imaginative

⁸⁴ Michele Miller Sigg, "The Dictionary of African Christian Biography and the Story of Ethiopian Christianity," *International Bulletin of Missionary Research*, 206.

⁸⁵ Werner H. Kelber, *The Oral and the Written Gospel: The Hermeneutics of Speaking and Writing in the Synoptic Tradition, Mark, Paul, and Q* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1983), 24–25.

⁸⁶ Abiola Irele, "Orality, Literacy, and African Literature," in *African Literature: An Anthology of Criticism and Theory*, ed. Tejumola Olaniyan and Ato Quayson (Malden, MD: Blackwell, 2013), 75.

⁸⁷ Irele, "Orality, Literacy, and African Literature," 75.

expression,” which are experienced “as the outline of a verbal structure and as reference points for the development of ideas and images, as suggestive signposts in the narrative or prosodic movement of discourse that is still in the future.”⁸⁸ Despite the emergence of textual documentation, oral communication remains the most common form in Africa. It remains the most crucial channel for transmitting history for the following reasons, as Irele indicates. First, “the oral text is rarely fully determined beforehand, given once and for all as is the case in written literature,” and second, “an oral text is actualised in oral performance and is thus open and mobile” and can be given new meaning as “the verbal content of a written work is perpetually recreated, modified as the occasion demands, and given a new accent” by different hearers and performers.⁸⁹

Ideas from Paul Ricoeur and the African literary tradition, as explicated by Irele, can help explore what happens when an individual’s biography is put into textual form or celebrated in the collective memory of the group. I am concerned here with individuals who have died, the African ancestors, and the importance of narrative as a cultural tool for writing African Christian history. It has become commonplace in many parts of the world, including Africa, to write biographies of people who are still alive and to write one’s own story. Writing the stories of the so-called living ancestors can have value, but their stories are incomplete. However, for many African pioneers of the faith, as well as for so many witnesses of the faith who have died and whose lives helped reveal to Africans the footprints of God, it is essential to retrieve their stories and reflect on their words and deeds. Particularly in theology and pastoral life, it is necessary to pay attention to what our African theologians and teachers have written and to how their examples can guide us and offer hope to many.

I propose an individual biography involves three related operations: the text (the story, either written or communicated orally, of the African Christian ancestor), the context (the community—faith or non-faith—and the place of interaction with the other, the cosmos, nature, and the spiritual or non-spiritual world), and the pretext (the experience of the community of the individual that preceded the life of the individual whose biography is being written). I see the individual biography as a text. The text of the individual biography can be understood only through the context and the pretext of the community (prosopography) into which the individual’s text or story is embedded.⁹⁰

Ricoeur draws attention to three helpful attributes: the importance of telling the story of individuals and locating the individual’s story in the wider context of the society or culture in which they lived.

The first attribute concerns the importance and environment of narration. Writing the biography of an African ancestor begins by explaining and interpreting

⁸⁸ Irele, “Orality, Literacy, and African Literature,” 81.

⁸⁹ Irele, “Orality, Literacy, and African Literature,” 80.

⁹⁰ See also Stan Chu Ilo and Gunda Werner, “Identity within Identities: Communicative Theology Through Biography,” in *Anders Gemeinsam—Gemeinsam Anders? In Ambivalenzen Lebendig Kommunizieren*, ed. Maria Juen (Hergestell, Germany: Matthias Grunewald, 2015), 152–53.

past events and connecting them to their continuation in the present. The writer must enter into the individual's history and the context in which the individual grew up. Ricoeur proposes that the success of such an entry "depends on our ability to follow a story."⁹¹ However, following a story is not simply a matter of chronology; it is about recounting a person's life from birth to death. Ricoeur adds another dimension to narration, since:

The activity of narrating does not consist simply of adding episodes to one another; it also constructs meaningful totalities out of scattered events. This aspect of the art of narration is reflected in the attempt to 'grasp together' successive events as one follows a story. Therefore, the art of narrating and the corresponding art of following a story require that we can extract a configuration from a succession.⁹²

Following a story involves a succession of activities and immersion in the world and in the ecclesial and social contexts of the person whose life is being documented. To write a biography is to bring together layers of meaning and reflect, as Ricoeur proposes, on events with the aim of "encompassing them in successive totalities."⁹³ What this means in writing African theology through the lives of those who have gone before us, marked with the sign of the faith, is that documentation of biographies, in the words of Benjamin, involves "a lot of digging beyond the surface." This might include going through community sources (the context), the worldview and social facts (the pretext), and returning to the same matter, "to scatter it as one scatters earth, to turn it over as one turns over soil. For 'the matter itself' is no more than the strata which yield their long-sought secrets only to the most meticulous investigation."⁹⁴

The second point from Ricoeur is that a person's life story is not fully captured by textual documentation alone. Documentation belongs to the community as much as the person whose biography is written. What is reported is also an open book that continues to grow, because it is part of the communicative process that makes and upholds the community in its historicity. The individual biography grows out of the context of communal history, because, as Ricoeur proposes, "we belong to history before telling stories or writing history. The game of telling is included in the reality told."⁹⁵ In his view, the writing of an individual's story gathers many streams and fragments of untold stories and random events, which all come together in an intelligible portrait of the person. This takes into account the temporal distance between the writer and the event or the person's life.⁹⁶

⁹¹ Paul Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur: Hermeneutics and the Human Sciences*, ed. and trans. John B. Thompson (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981), 278.

⁹² Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 278.

⁹³ Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 279.

⁹⁴ Benjamin, "Excavation and Memory," 576.

⁹⁵ Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 294.

⁹⁶ Paul Ricoeur, *Time and Narrative III*, trans. Kathleen Blamey and David Pellauer (Chicago: Chicago University Press, 1990), 167, 181; see also Henry Isaac Venema, *Identifying Selfhood: Imagination, Narrative, and Hermeneutics in the Thoughts of Paul Ricoeur* (Albany, NY: State

Ricoeur's third point is that the African Christian ancestor comes alive in a new way that grows beyond the text: "A text is any discourse fixed by writing. According to this definition, fixation by writing is constitutive of the text itself."⁹⁷ He makes clear that the text serves as a substitute for speech. It also takes the place of the oral communicator for their audience and opens a different kind of dialogue for the text's subsequent readers. Orality precedes literacy, but fixation in writing is not a new event of meaning, nor does it surpass or nullify the value of speech. Instead, it guarantees the "persistence of speech."⁹⁸

The relationship between text and oral tradition is dynamic. For Ricoeur, writing takes the place of speech and liberates discourse from the oral situation. However, this preservation in textual form leads to "veritable upheaval in the relations between language and the world, as well as in the relation between language and the various subjectivities concerned (that of the author and that of the reader)."⁹⁹ Ricoeur adduces this in holding that "the intention-to-say" comes before writing.¹⁰⁰ This "intention-to-say" is loaded in dynamic collective memory. Ricoeur claims that "writing preserves discourse and makes it an archive available for individual and collective memory."¹⁰¹

But writing does not exhaust the range of possibilities for documenting history. We must welcome other forms of historical storage and aesthetics, such as works of art, symbols, music, myths, drama, and fiction. As Ricoeur asserts, writing may "emancipate from the oral situation," but there is no absolute text; the text must constantly return to the oral situation. Instances arise in which the oral situation is the only collective archive available beyond textual fixation.¹⁰²

According to Ricoeur, every narrative describes reality, that is, what happened, whether written, spoken, or stored in collective memory. This reality is a history of someone, some people, cultures, or events. This history is "around the surroundings and the circumstantial milieu of discourse." Every narrative text must return to the reality that gave birth to the discourse, the person, or the plot. A fixed discourse constantly "pours back into the universe" and reconnects to the world. This world is mediated by meaning, encompassing the context and pretext of the documented life story (text).¹⁰³

This line of argument is pursued in recent scholarship by Dale Martin, who proposes that the task of the Christian community, or the community of readers of a biblical text, is not simply to be passive receptors. He debunks the myth of textual agency by arguing that the text is a product of the community and a gift to be

University of New York Press, 2000), 56.

⁹⁷ Paul Ricoeur, *From Text to Action: Essays in Hermeneutics* (London: Continuum International, 2008), 106.

⁹⁸ Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 146.

⁹⁹ Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 147.

¹⁰⁰ Ricoeur, *From Text to Action*, 107.

¹⁰¹ Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 149.

¹⁰² Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 148.

¹⁰³ Cf. Ricoeur, *Paul Ricoeur*, 148.

interpreted and received. This also applies to the reading and documentation of a person's life.¹⁰⁴ This will challenge those who hold to the literalism of the biblical text without paying attention to the whole truth it communicates, which cannot be mediated solely through the text.

Fundamental in Ricoeur's view are the lack of finality to textual documentation, the importance of storytelling as communal participatory action, and the need for ongoing renewal of the text (the written biography). These are determined by: (1) how the story emerges from the participatory actions of the community members and flows back into the community. (2) How it renews the community through its referential and reconfiguring effects. (3) How further conversation and conversion are stimulated within the community through the referential function of explanation and interpretation. (5) How the space between the past and present history is bridged. Ricoeur writes:

If reading is possible, it is because the text is not closed in on itself but opens out onto other things. To read is, on any hypothesis, to conjoin a new discourse to the discourse of the text. This conjunction of discourses reveals, in the very constitution of the text, an original capacity for renewal which is its open character.¹⁰⁵

Recent scholarship in the social sciences calls attention to a shift away from the epistemologies of the North and the methodological canons that have long been regnant in the social sciences and in theological and religious studies. Instead, greater attention is being given to "people's everyday practices."¹⁰⁶ Scholars writing about communities that suffered from injustice and oppression show that the text of one's life can be understood only within these larger contexts and pretexts of the individual. For instance, writing an individual's biography in Africa will be a communal cultural-historical genetic project. It brings together a network of meanings, traces of history, and residues of the past about particular communities, and gives them freshness and new light. When received through oral tradition, as is often the case, regions of meanings embedded in forgotten history are illumined and uncovered. Henry Louis Gates argues that it is only by telling their own stories and the stories of their heroes and heroines that many people on the margins can reclaim a sense of dignity, healing, and the restoration of history. Also, systemic grounds can be created for the troubled account of their history. Gates proposes a narrative ethic: "I write myself, therefore I am."¹⁰⁷

Writing African Christian history requires immersion in African indigenous

¹⁰⁴ Dale B. Martin, *Sex and the Single Saviour: Gender and Sexuality in Biblical Interpretation* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2006), 1–16.

¹⁰⁵ Paul Ricoeur, 158.

¹⁰⁶ See Michel de Certeau, "Railway Navigation and Incarceration," trans. Steven Rendall, in *The City Cultures Reader*, 2nd ed., ed. Malcolm Miles, Tim Hall, Iain Borden (London, Routledge, 2004), 266.

¹⁰⁷ See Angela Dillard, *Guess Who's Coming to Dinner Now? Multicultural Conservatism in America* (New York: New York University Press, 2001), 100.

languages. This will be mediated through oral narratives, and familiarity with the hidden cultural grammar that defines the intentionality of particular cultural texts, pretexts, and contexts is needed. Also required are attempts to make a connection; to see the network of meanings between individual witnesses across different contexts of faith in Africa; and to see the value of African religions, their moral and spiritual universe, and their retention and expansion within the received patterns and emerging shape of African Christianity. The result will be a communal, participatory celebration of what is moving history forward.

This is the difference between what the missionary historians accomplished in documenting African history and the kind of history demonstrated through the community contributions and African participatory practices in sharing and retelling the stories in the DACB. Emmanuel Obiechina notes that, beginning in the late nineteenth century, missionaries were the main agents in collecting and recording in writing African oral traditions—folktales, fables, myths, proverbs, riddles, songs, and historical fragments.¹⁰⁸ The missionary efforts and documentation fail to recognise Africans’ participation in adapting African languages to Western scripts and in translating biblical and religious-education books into vernaculars.¹⁰⁹

Most of these endeavours were not community experiences, nor were they aimed at writing an African Christian history focusing on the contributions of Africans as missionaries to fellow Africans. Kalu argues that the resulting history was limited and biased: “Missionary ideology tended to share the scientific racism of the nineteenth century. Thus, missionary historiography is often hagiographic, triumphalist, and disdainful of Indigenous non-European cultures. As Peter Foster put it, a premium was put upon distortion and degradation of receiving cultures.”¹¹⁰ Another sad aspect of this kind of history is the absence of women’s voices, as Obiechina renders it, in the telling of stories: “Women and children sit still and say nothing.”¹¹¹ He might be speaking from a limited African tribal context, because, as Mary Modupe Kolawole has shown with historical evidence in Central Sudan, the role of grandmothers in storytelling is so dominant that grandmothers, *habboba*, constitute a distinctive cultural institution. Suppose that, in some settings, oral tradition demonised women through proverbs, folktales, and legends. In that case, it is essential (in endeavours like the DACB) to give voice to women’s contributions as a source of virtue and value in oral traditions and history.¹¹²

Memory and the Narrative of African Christian Biographies

¹⁰⁸ Emmanuel N. Obiechina, *Language and Theme: Essays in African Literature* (Washington, DC: Howard University Press), 9.

¹⁰⁹ Obiechina, *Language and Theme*, 9.

¹¹⁰ Kalu, “Introduction,” 14.

¹¹¹ Obiechina, *Language and Theme*, 14.

¹¹² Mary E. Modupe Kolawole, “Women’s Oral Genres,” in *African Literature: An Anthology of Criticism and Theory*, ed. Tejumola Olaniyan and Ato Quayson (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2007), 95.

Many African historians argue that to understand African history, one must study African oral traditions. To understand oral tradition, one must deeply understand the African language of discourse, especially the art of storytelling. African ethnic groups are storytelling societies rather than logocentric (word-centred) ones. In such a world, life is a portrait cast in stories about the interaction between a moral and spiritual universe and people's everyday practices. Stories bring together connections of shared participation and mutual interaction between nature and Spirit, humans and non-humans, God and humanity, the living and the dead, and animals and humans.¹¹³ Obiechina describes the Igbo of Eastern Nigeria:

The Igbo have always remembered that they have a tree, and their storytellers have constantly reminded them of the need to tend it. For them, stories are important because they are anchored in memory. For them, the story is eternal; it belongs in time but has a timeless quality. Its power to instruct, to remind, to renew, and to direct is not circumscribed by time. So that in their travels and through all vicissitudes of flux and change, they carry a memory instructed by their stories.¹¹⁴

The persistence of stories in African culture is anchored in memory. A community remembers because, in traditional African society, memory is the storehouse of the people's worldview. It is the repository of people's great stories and deeds in their cultural and religious history. Memory furnishes interpretive keys for understanding time and space. It is also key to understanding the past, present, and future. Whether one speaks of cyclical time, temporal time, or genealogies, the stream of consciousness embedded in history can be understood in African ontology and African Christian narrative only by entering this memory bank. This storehouse is also mediated through the lives of community members of faith.

The importance of oral tradition, or the so-called 'memorial culture,' as a source of valid history has been challenged by the 'hard school of history,' which argues that "proper history must be reconstructed from written documentary sources of sufficient vantage and, therefore, sufficient distance from the events it is concerned with."¹¹⁵ This challenge can be met by entering into the story of the past, using the conveyor belts of memory with humility and reverence. Further, every tool possible can be deployed to show that the African past—religious, political, economic, social, and spiritual—is not "one long night of savagery from which the first Europeans acting on God's behalf delivered them."¹¹⁶

How does the writing of a Christian biography become a pilgrimage into a

¹¹³ See Emmanuel Obiechina, *Nchetaka: The Story, Memory and Continuity in Igbo Culture*, Ahajioku Lecture 1994 (Owerri, Nigeria: Ministry of Information and Social Development, 1994), 26.

¹¹⁴ Obiechina, *Nchetaka*, 47.

¹¹⁵ G. N. Uzoigwe, "A Half Century of Historical Writing in Africa, 1950–2000," in *Emergent Themes and Methods in African Studies: Essays in Honour of Adiele E. Afigbo*, ed. Toyin Falola and Adam Paddock (Trenton, NJ: African World Press, 2009), 112.

¹¹⁶ Chinua Achebe, *Hopes and Impediments: Selected Essays* (New York: Anchor, 1990), 45.

spiritual communal memory and a spiritual portrait of the lives of African ancestors of faith? How does it become a sacred walk into a hallowed archive offering a portrait of God's mission and God's footprints to guide African Christian communities?

Communicating God's Word in Africa requires paying attention to how God continues to reveal the seed of God's Word in the lives of individuals who, in the economy of grace, live the Gospel in concrete history in their own ways. In writing theology, in one sense, I am writing myself. In writing a Christian biography, I am also writing myself, because the life of the person whose biography I write has a family trait woven with my own life, in our vocation and participation in the mission of God in history.

This personal or subjective condition for believing and for communicating is described in 1 John 1–4:

What was from the beginning, what we have heard, what we have seen with our eyes, what we have looked at and touched with our hands, concerning the Word of Life—and the life was manifested, and we have seen and testify and proclaim to you the eternal life, which was with the Father and was manifested to us—what we have seen and heard we proclaim to you also, so that you too may have fellowship with us; and indeed our fellowship is with the Father, and with His Son Jesus Christ.

These things we write, so that our joy may be made complete.

The biography of any Christian witness is a portrait of the faith and life of the community that shaped the Christian and was, in turn, shaped by the Christian witness to the mission of God. In writing that biography, one is writing the history not of any individual but of a community. The writer is accounting for the mission of God in history and entering into that history as part of a long stream of faith and life that goes back to the beginning of all things in God.

Writing African Christian history through biographies poses a challenge for accounting for the mission of God in history. What, for instance, is the canon for inclusion and exclusion when we write the history of the Christian faith in Africa? Is a piece of literature 'theological' or 'Christian' because it grounds itself in the writings of the Fathers and the teaching of the Magisterium? Is it because it proof-texts from the Bible and makes appeals to essential voices from the Western Church? Who determines how a particular history of faith reveals the true face of God's mission in history?

The DACB is a counter-hegemonic accounting of God's mission in Africa. The DACB gives voice to stories from the margins—local leaders, ordinary African Christians, women, and those whose heroic lives may not have shone amid the small constellation of ecclesial stars. Church histories are based on official faith and official accounts in church records. Any inclusion in this account is based on how faithfully the few Africans mentioned lived, as described by particular churches. Africans who tried to live their African expression of the Christian faith may not have been included because such Africanization of Christianity was not acceptable in the old map of church history.

The DACB offers a unique approach. It goes beyond official faith and official church records to immersion in the actual faith of the people and paying attention to

an ecumenical account of what God is doing in African Christian history. The openness of the DACB's approach reveals the dynamic movement of Christian history in Africa, which breaks down walls because it does not fit into any previous category or framework of history mediated by denominational wars. The DACB also recognises that African Christian history is a continuing act of the Apostles, with many surprises of the Holy Spirit. The things that African Christians consider essential to the life of a Christian, and what they celebrate as spiritual light and the irruption of God's power in a person's life, may seem bizarre to some non-Africans. However, in the DACB documents, writers regard these new ways of witnessing as valid expressions of a Christian faith. The transmission of this faith in Africa requires humility for all those who seek to find God's footprints in African history.

Writing African Theology through Biography: Biblical Models

I propose two principles, among many, from biblical theology for writing African theology by harvesting the stories of our African Christian ancestors. Theology is always an account of God's presence or absence in history; this understanding of theology illuminates two principles for understanding the mission of God in African Christian history.

The first principle concerns the validity of Christian biography and oral communication as sources of history. It concerns the importance of storytelling as a communication medium in most African traditions. It is also about how the spoken Word can produce "the actuality of what they refer to among the people."¹¹⁷

I see this emerging pattern particularly in the new approaches to doing theology in Africa, which involve collecting stories of the actual faith of God's people. These include my research and the works of Joe Healey (in small Christian communities in Africa) and Emmanuel Katongole, whose works we engaged with in chapter two.

The task of theology is accountability—what the writer of Luke-Acts calls an "ordered account" of what has happened after careful consideration of the facts.¹¹⁸ The great deeds of God show what is moving forward in particular and group history. This justifies the now largely accepted conclusion that every theology is contextual, growing out of a particular history and paying attention to the social change that emerges from that culture, as well as the daily struggle of the people for survival and their search for God.¹¹⁹ Theology holds an essential place in the life of the people because it is a human cultural instrument for giving an account of the faith. Doing theology is a grace-filled moment through which the theologian and the community of faith seek to understand

¹¹⁷ See Kelber, *The Oral and the Written Gospel*, 19.

¹¹⁸ "Many people have set out to write accounts about the events that have been fulfilled among us. They used the eyewitness reports circulating among us from the early disciples. Having carefully investigated everything from the beginning, I have also decided to write a careful account for you, most honourable Theophilus, so you can be certain of the truth of everything you were taught" Luke 1:14.

¹¹⁹ Stephen Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 2001), 1, 10.

the place and principle of faith in the daily choices of people of faith as they bring about the reign of God. Theology is the history of God's deeds—past, present, and yet to come. The theologian has a nose for the fragrance of God in all things and the motivation to follow the stories of God's mighty deeds through the daily stories of people, the living and the dead. The results demonstrate the rationality of faith, and the concreteness of "hope that does not disappoint" (Romans 5:5). The African theologian, in particular, is one who constantly demonstrates how the Word of God takes concrete forms in individual lives, and how the diverse experiences of individuals and communities lead to or away from God, through the shape and texture of God's mission and our participation in this mission.

Theology is valid only when it locates in these stories the portrait of how God's people are bringing about God's reign in history through their daily lives. African theology is a narration which does not cease to grow. Even when set in a fixed form in text, it exudes fuller dimensions beyond the text because it is born of a dynamic environment. The theologian was traditionally regarded as the master of the sacred pages. If this definition is still valid, African theologians must become masters and mistresses of the holy steps of God in the lived Christianity of our ancestors. They are to follow the stories of the footprints of God in God's great and small deeds in the lives and contexts of our African Christian ancestors, and those models of life and faith whom we encounter around us as modern prophets and heroes of faith. These points can be better understood by paying attention to the collection and development of biblical texts.

The aforementioned 'Bible in Africa Project' offers examples of the formation of the biblical text, which strikes me as similar to what African theologians do when they collect the stories of faith of our people, especially the forgotten stories of our African Christian ancestors.¹²⁰ The missionary mandate 'go and proclaim the good news' (cf. Mark 16:15, Matthew 28:19), which, according to this research, emphasizes oral communication and transmission, remains the primary means of sharing the Word of God in Africa. In most instances, for non-literal respondents interviewed in this research, hearing the Word of God aloud produced greater passion and purpose in their faith journey than reading the Bible. Oral communication has a direct and immediate pneumatic impact, relating more to the spiritual power of God's Word as conveyed and received through hearing and receiving the message of God's life.' The Word has power not because it is written, but because African audiences are moved by the power of the Word, as received through proclamation, preaching, performance, and ritualization of the Word in Christian worship and praxis. Researchers have noted the importance of the spoken Word in African culture, and how it plays an integral part in Africans' direct connection to the Word of God and its power to bless and curse.¹²¹ Oral communication is valid in the Church as a form of witnessing to the Word of God and the words of ancestors, which must be passed down to share in the wisdom and abundance of life they mediate.

¹²⁰ Ukpong, "Popular Readings of the Bible," 582–94.

¹²¹ Ukpong, "Popular Readings of the Bible," 582–94.

The second principle from biblical theology, used in African theology through stories of African Christian ancestors, relates to the first. Writing about the lives of our African ancestors is like the experience of the writers who collected the traditions and history of the significant figures in Scripture. Biblical theologies, especially of the Old Testament and the formation of the New Testament canon, attest that oral tradition precedes, accompanies, and validates written tradition. Kelber argues there was an oral heterogeneity in the development of the synoptic gospels, which in the Gospel of Mark diverges into a plurality of forms and directions, such that “variability and stability, conservatism and creativity, evanescence and unpredictability all mark the pattern of oral transmission.”¹²² This does not mean that orality and memory are unreliable, but it shows the richness and depth of what God is doing. Such can not easily be contained within a single linear account, either in the formation of the biblical canons or in the documentation of individual Christians’ lives. Using James Wilkinson’s distinction between written history and oral tradition, oral tradition contains traces of the past that continue. In contrast, written text shows traces of this residue. The written form does not exhaust the oral form, but is a pointer to it.¹²³

Paul Bere sees the oral finality of the biblical text as imposing formal constraints upon the written version. Rendition in textual form does not nullify the value of memory or orality. Hence the term ‘Word of God’ rather than ‘text of God,’ or ‘literature of God,’ or ‘book of God.’ Bere notes that the authorial audience comprises first hearers; both the readers of the written text and hearers of the Word proclaimed orally rely on the memory bank of traditions to harvest the message communicated by God. Both must hear God’s Word spoken to their hearts and engraved there as a precondition for entering the covenant. Traditionally, Christians have concerned themselves with hearing and listening to God’s Word.

Regarding the biblical tradition, orality and aurality cannot be separated in the written and unwritten communication of God’s Word. This is essential for understanding the priority of memory and orality as performative for any subsequent written account. It also cautions against limiting the documentation of oral traditions and the humility needed to recognize that every document is incomplete. A crack must be left in a textual rendition for textuality that can never be exhausted.¹²⁴

Writing biographies in contexts like Africa is not only consistent with the formation of biblical traditions but also with that of other traditions. It also opens the front door and widens the door to what one could analogically call the ‘fifth gospel’ being written in Africa. David Carr shows that the formation of the biblical tradition combined orality and textuality, but with emphasis on aurality, that is, hearing the Word, retaining what is heard (memory), and performing what is read (praxis-in-history).¹²⁵

¹²² Kelber, *The Oral and the Written Gospel*, 33.

¹²³ Kelber, *The Oral and the Written Gospel*, 33.

¹²⁴ See Paul Bere, “Auditor in Fabula-La Bible dans son Contexte oral: Le cas du Livre de Ruth,” *Journal of the Old Testament Society of South Africa* 19, no. 3 (2006): 1089–1105.

¹²⁵ David M. Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart: Origins of Scripture and Literature* (Oxford:

In some OT passages, God tells Moses to write the law on a stone tablet, but in other texts, God tells the prophet Jeremiah to write it on the tablets of the heart. For example, in Jeremiah 31:33: "I will put my torah teaching within them, and I will write it on their hearts." Another example is in Ezekiel 2:9, 3:3:

I looked; a hand was stretched to me, and a written scroll was in it. He spread it before me; it had writing on the front and back, and words of lamentation, mourning, and woe were written. He said to me, O mortal, eat what is offered to you; eat this scroll, and go, speak to the house of Israel. He told me, Mortal, eat this scroll I give you and fill your stomach with it. Then I ate it, and it was as sweet as honey.

Eating the scroll can be understood as revering it in individual and collective memory, performing it in rituals and songs, and living it out in practice. Carr points out the apparent tension between eating the scroll (a text) and communicating it in words to the people (orally).¹²⁶

The text moves from the textual ingesting of the scroll to the oral communication of its content. According to Carr, the world of the prophets envisions a place "where figures like prophets could hold entire texts in their minds and hearts, which they then orally communicated to Israelites."¹²⁷ This does not nullify writing, but it does show that we cannot understand the transmission of divine revelation in biblical times or the formation of the Christian canon without paying greater attention to the effects of memory and oral communication.

According to Robert Culley, in the writings of H. M. and N. K. Chadwick and of Sigmund Mowinckel, there is copious evidence that fixation in textual record was achieved through oral transmission. However, fixation in textual form did not exhaust the meaning of the oral tradition, nor does the existence of oral tradition without textual fixation mean that the tradition is open to an infinite range of renditions according to individual preference. Media such as moral prescriptions, myths, songs, prayers, rituals, liturgical celebrations, and dance limit an individual's attempt to overextend a tradition's content or oral text. The distinction between fixed written form and the unfixed oral form lies in the performance of the Word through cultural symbols, behaviors, artifacts, spirituality, norms, and images, as well as in the arts and songs.¹²⁸ Another example is the song of the suffering servant of Deutero-Isaiah (Isaiah 50:4-6), where the prophet graphically proclaims:

The Lord YHWH has given me the tongue of a teacher, that I may know how to sustain the weary with the Word. Morning by morning, he wakes. He yearns to listen to those who are taught. The Lord God has opened my ear, and I was not rebellious; I did not turn backwards.

The theme of an open ear through which will pass the "scroll of the book" is

Oxford University Press, 2005), 149.

¹²⁶ Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart*, 149.

¹²⁷ Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart*, 149.

¹²⁸ Robert C. Culley, "An Approach to the Problem of Oral Tradition," *Vetus Testamentum* 13, no. 2 (April 2, 1963): 115–17.

reflected again in Psalm 40:7-9.

These are a few of the numerous instances in Carr's work that help appreciate the importance of oral traditions in biblical literature and how they offer a strong biblical foundation and an invitation to writing African theology through the biographies of our African ancestors. Writing the biography of the individual African Christian does not exhaust the story of faith in that particular milieu; it is a spark and an opening to the living environment of faith, which is constantly expanding. Documenting the life of an African Christian ancestor does not necessarily preclude further documentation of the oral traditions. Oral tradition in Ancient Israel was similar: "These bodies of early Jewish literature—the Mishnah and the Yerushalmi—come from a period where rabbinic teaching is taken to be specifically 'oral,' even thematized as part of the 'oral torah.' Indeed, there are clear strictures against the formation of comprehensive records of these traditions."¹²⁹ The rabbis felt that documenting oral traditions in writing might close the ever-expanding revelation of God's footprints in oral communication, which constantly yields new dimensions and information that cannot be found in a fixed text.

Justifications for this insistence on orality are found in the works of Carr and Birger Gerhardsson.¹³⁰ First, the use of oral communication in the OT was a form of cultural resistance to hegemonic political and cultural forces, especially when the rendition was in a foreign language. According to Carr, subsequent rendition into text of the oral tradition in the OT (for instance, in Hebrew) was for the Jews a cultural resistance. They rejected the idea that the medium for conserving the sacred story of the histories and foundation of God's people should be a foreign language like Greek or Latin, the language of their oppressors. Carr argues that an oral communicator is often forced to resist alien linguistic forms to capture original experiences in the form in which they occurred, through a return to autochthonous linguistic forms. For many Jewish scholars, he asserts, the LXX (the Greek version of the Hebrew Scriptures) had been tainted by Hellenistic influence. Thus, there was an insistence on the return to the memory bank, the storehouse of indigenous language and expressions, to reinforce the images, forms, and cultural elements of the cultures of ancient Israel.

Oral communication in African theology is also subversive of methodologies that follow pre-established canons of orthodoxy and standardized ecclesial language. However, the translation of oral texts into written texts in biographies by Church historians or African theologians must increasingly be aware of the limits of this enterprise. Challenges of translation and exploitation may arise if there is a power differential or social distance between the narrative language of the recipients of the oral text (in their mother tongue) and the written text in a foreign language.

The second justification is that Christians emphasized orality in ways similar to

¹²⁹ Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart*, 277.

¹³⁰ Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart*, 277; see also Birger Gerhardsson, *Memory and Manuscript: Oral Tradition and Written Transmission in Rabbinic Judaism and Early Christianity* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1998), 19–42.

their rabbinic Jewish counterparts.¹³¹ Early Christians relied on memory to communicate the OT and retain and transmit their experience of the living Lord. Clear evidence for this is the concluding part of the Gospel of John: “There are many other things which Jesus did, but were they to be collected in one book, there will be no book to hold them” (John 21:25). This passage is a key justification for a narrative approach to doing theology in Africa through collecting oral bibliographical data. Many great deeds of God are happening in Africa; these cannot be contained in a single medium of communication, whether the ones written by white people or the ones now being written by Africans. However, they are housed in the collective memories of particular Christian groups and communities of faith, in forms that need to be encountered and harvested. Just as Jesus did and said, it continues in our times, and the deeds of the Christian ancestors of Africa continue beyond space and time.¹³²

Conclusion

In this discourse, I have described the importance of narration and memory in African theology through the documentation of biographies of African Christian ancestors. Theologians, church historians, and scholars who have contributed to this volume have followed God’s footprints in Africa by listening to the stories of our women ancestors. They have paid attention to the larger context of the ancestors’ lives in the community, the different historical moments that shaped their lives, the lives of others in the community, and the community at large.

I propose that these life texts and biographies are open theological books which emerge from the communities, and that these accounts pour back into the community. Doing African theology and cultivating African Christian spirituality by telling the stories of African ancestors is like developing the biblical traditions from oral to written texts. As with the biblical texts, I see a rendition of the biography in textual form, not signaling finality for the continuing revelations and dimensions of God’s deeds through the lives of a particular African Christian ancestor. In reading textual documentation of the lives of African ancestors, African Christians and their brothers and sisters in the world Church can listen again and again to the Word of God proclaimed through the faith and witness of African Christians. They are thus inspired to follow in God’s footsteps in our particular history and to discover how the ancestors’ lives continue to encourage God’s mission in their communities.

¹³¹ Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart*, 279.

¹³² Carr, *Writing on the Table of the Heart*, 279.

Book Review

Africa Bears Witness: Mission Theology and Praxis in the 21st Century (2024).
Edited by Harvey Kwiyani, United Kingdom: Langham Global Library.

Reviewed by Stephen Apollo Warui.¹³³

In this edited volume of fifteen chapters, the authors present Africa not merely as a passive recipient of mission or a peripheral player in missiology, but as a key contributor to global Christianity and a central participant in God's mission. Without diminishing the interconnectedness of Western and African Christianities, the authors call for a departure from dominant paradigms and histories that privilege Western missionary frameworks and cultural imperialism. The book seeks to recover African perspectives, experiences, and trends in mission and advocates a contemporary vision of African missiology, or missiology "cooked in an African pot."

The chapters collectively develop several interconnected themes that can be grouped into five overarching categories. The first category is Africa as a Global Missionary Force. The book's central argument is that Africa has become a significant missionary center within world Christianity. Rather than merely receiving missionaries, African churches now shape global Christianity through theology, evangelism, migration, and missionary initiatives. The major emphasis is on the shift from mission to Africa to mission in and from Africa, highlighting Africa's growing theological influence and the recognition of African Christianity as a major voice in the twenty-first century.

The second category is Mission through Prophetic Witness. The authors argue that Christian mission entails transformative engagement with society, not merely evangelism and church growth. They present a holistic understanding of mission that encompasses spiritual, social, economic, and political dimensions. The Church, they insist, is called to confront injustice, corruption, violence, and political oppression while pursuing social transformation and development. Chapters addressing these themes include Mission in *Prophetic Dialogue*, *Kenosis as Missional Strategy for a Church in Need of Conversion*, *Catalytic Church Mission and Peacebuilding*, and *Mission and Development*.

The third category is Contextual Mission. The book emphasizes that mission must be expressed in ways that resonate with African cultures and worldviews, arguing that effective mission requires contextualization rather than transplanting foreign models. African culture is presented not as an obstacle but as a resource and a gift for mission. The authors contend that African mission should emerge from African realities, emphasizing informal theological education, urban mission, indigenous worship (*pambio*), the use of local languages, and contextual leadership formation. The emphasis throughout is practical rather than merely theoretical. In this way, culture becomes a vehicle for communicating the gospel and strengthening Christian identity.

¹³³ Stephen Apollo Warui is a PhD student at Boston University School of Theology at the Center for Global Christianity and Mission, and DACB Assistant Editor.

Relevant chapters include *Africa Bears Witness*, *Mission as New Catholicity*, *Afro-Westernization and Globalization*, *Contextualized Missions and Theological Education in the Global South*, and *The Pambio in Mission*.

The fourth category is Pentecostal and Charismatic Renewal. Several chapters examine the profound influence of Pentecostal and Charismatic Christianity on African mission. Topics include the Holy Spirit in mission, charismatic renewal, urban Pentecostal movements, and neo-prophetic ministries. Rather than dismissing these movements, the book critically evaluates their strengths and challenges. The central argument is that Pentecostal and Charismatic movements are among the most influential expressions of African Christianity. African Christianity is increasingly pneumatic in character, as Asamoah-Gyadu describes it, “pneumatic Christianity.” Consequently, it is impossible to discuss African Christianity without engaging this dimension. Chapters covering these themes include *In the Power of the Spirit*, *African Charismatic Movements and Urban Missiology*, and *Neo-Prophetism and Rebranding of Missio Dei in African Christianity*.

The fifth category is the Formation of Indigenous African Missiology. The volume intentionally broadens the range of voices shaping mission in Africa, insisting that African voices must define African missiology. Mission is presented as participatory rather than dominated by institutional elites. Notably, African women are portrayed as central participants in God’s mission. As the majority of African Christians, women have been the backbone of evangelism, discipleship, prayer, and church growth. Consequently, African mission cannot be fully understood without recognizing their contributions. The book therefore argues that African women’s theology of mission is necessary not only for Africa but also for the wider context of World Christianity.

The book also examines migration and reverse mission, framing African migration as a missionary opportunity. Migration is understood as part of God’s ongoing mission in the world, and African Christianity is portrayed as a missionary force beyond Africa, with African Christians increasingly serving as missionaries in Europe, North America, and elsewhere. Chapters addressing these themes include *African Women in Mission*, *African American Mission Work*, *African Christians and Missionaries in Europe*, and *Missiology for a Youthful Continent*.

While this book presents important themes in African Christianity and missiology, it has notable omissions. Given Africa’s religious diversity, one might have expected a chapter on mission in pluralistic contexts, particularly one addressing mission in relation to Islam and African Primal Religions. Another conspicuous omission is eco-mission. Given Africa’s vulnerability to climate change, this is a significant gap. There are also other areas that are uniquely important to the African context. One is the health and healing mission. Although development and peacebuilding are addressed, the book offers no explicit treatment of medical missions. Given the historical importance of Christian healthcare in Africa, this omission is notable.

Another overlooked area is migration within Africa, which offers significant missionary opportunities. The authors focus primarily on Africa-to-Europe migration. Less attention is given to refugee ministries, internally displaced persons, cross-border

African migration, and mission among migrants within the continent. These omissions do not necessarily constitute weaknesses. Rather, they identify areas in which a future companion volume could significantly expand the conversation on African missiology.

Recent Print and Digital Resources Related to Christianity in Africa

Compiled by Beth Restrick, Head, BU African Studies Library

African Synodal Theology: A Tall Tree is as Strong as its Roots.

Agbonkhanmeghe Orobator. Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2025. \$29.59 (pbk) www.amazon.com ISBN-13: 979-8888660980

Description: The word “synodality” means “journey together.” For Pope Francis, synodality is “an expression of the Church’s nature, her form, style, and mission.” And yet, now several years on this synodal path, it remains an ecclesiology in need of a theology. This work, drawing on the voices of many of Africa’s leading Catholic theologians, is a response to that need, clarifying and deepening the understanding, knowledge, and practice of synodality in the local churches. Among the topics explored: the parallels between synodality and aspects of African spirituality and culture, including the concept of palaver and Ubuntu; the synodal implications of the Trinity; scriptural foundations and ecclesiological implications; the role of young people and women, and implications for authority and a listening church.

These reflections are a gift to the wider church, showing uniquely African ways of being community and doing things that can enhance the emergence of a synodal church and a true theology of synodality.

Christianity in Nigerian Politics: Overcoming the Storm. Ikechukwu Gregory Ugwu. Independently Published. 2025. \$20.00 (pbk) www.amazon.com ISBN-13: 979-8294202804

Description: In *Christianity in Nigerian Politics: Overcoming the Storm*, Dr. Ikechukwu Gregory Ugwu, a luminary in the Charismatic Renewal Ministries (CRM), rallies Nigerian Christians to brave the tempest of politics and forge Shalom—peace, prosperity, and wholeness. Nigeria, rich in oil, grapples with poverty, battered by storms of godfatherism, religious intolerance, corruption, and violence. Yet, as Jesus navigated the stormy sea (Mark 4:35), believers are called to rise as salt and light (Matthew 5:13–16). Led by Dr. Ugwu and The Nations Prayer Watch Initiative, this book unveils divine truths to set the church free (John 8:32), empowering Christians to transform governance.

Certified by the West Africa Theological Seminary (WATS), the book draws on interviews with Nigerian church leaders, intellectuals, and politicians, exposing barriers like corruption—Nigeria ranks 145th globally (Transparency International, 2024)—and religious violence, such as the 2025 Benue massacres (TruthNigeria, 2025). Historical divides from colonial legacies and the 1967–1970 Civil War fuel these challenges (Falola, 2018). The book critiques the church’s apathy, shaped by the prosperity gospel’s dominance since the 2000s, and heralds a divine shift toward leadership since 2020 (Kukah, 2015).

Supported by the CRM Board—Dr. Ugwu, Pastor Mrs. Udo Ugwu, Dr. Tosin Agbesanwa, Pastor Boniface Igbe, Dr. Bruno Aduo, Dr. Toyin Olu Jacob, Dr. Dipo Eweje, and Engr. Raph Onovo—the book proposes solutions: leadership training rooted in servant leadership (Greenleaf, 1977), godly sponsorship to counter godfatherism (Olarinmoye, 2011), intercessory prayer (1 Timothy 2:1–6), and advocacy to unite believers across divides (Oguntola-Laguda, 2010). These empower Christians to overcome barriers like the 2022 Deborah Samuel lynching (United States Department of State, 2024), fostering godly leaders.

Pastor Edwin Chukwuemezie Ezeh’s foreword underscores Dr. Ugwu’s CRM leadership and warns of apathy’s consequences, citing Turkey’s diminished Christian influence. Guided by patron Dr. Cosmas Ilechukwu and mentor Rev. Dr. Uma Ukpai, the book envisions a “divine precipitation” of God’s power. A beacon for Nigerian and global Christians, it urges pastors and believers to embrace politics as a divine calling, ensuring societies rejoice under righteous rule (Proverbs 29:2). Join this movement to transform Nigeria and beyond.

Open Access Resources

Abu, Joseph. “The Prospects and Challenges of Doing Missionary work in Contemporary Nigerian Society.” *Studia Theologica Varsaviensia*. Vol. 63, no. 1, 2025. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.21697/stv.15545>

Abstract: Contemporary culture is undoubtedly a technologically and scientifically based culture. Now and again, we witness a growing dynamism characterized by societal sophistication leading to an excessive emphasis on rationality with a distinct lack of faith. There seems to be a paradigm shift in the notion, understanding, and practice of religion today as it is gradually being eased out in many parts of the world. Religion, once a ‘teacher’, is now a ‘student’ contending for a seat in the ‘classroom of human affairs’. In the face of these social changes, the Catholic Church has remained a sign and a sacrament to the world. It is the moral voice that refuses to conform to worldly standards. Its mission has consistently remained the same, following the eternal plan of the Father, that the Church on earth is missionary by its very nature and has its origin in the mission of the Son and the Holy Spirit. If the mission of the Church in the world is to attain full realization, evangelization must constitute its truest and deepest identity. The church in Nigeria in union with the Universal Church has that important mission of spreading the gospel of Christ. Like any other institution, the Nigerian church faces multi-dimensional and multi-faceted challenges such as religious tensions, ethnic conflicts, insecurity and poor governance, youth underdevelopment and unemployment, syncretism, hedonism and so on. However, its growing receptiveness to the gospel of Christ as laid by the early evangelizers has provided a veritable roadmap for attaining the Church’s overall mission: the salvation of souls. This presentation seeks to underscore the prospects and challenges of doing missionary work in contemporary Nigerian society with particular reference to the proclamation and propagation of the Christian faith to guarantee its

steady growth and future expansion. This paper shall as well proffer some practical recommendations which can aid the Nigerian church maintain its relevance and identity amidst conflicting values and societal sophistication.

Patrick, Edet Okon, Jaja M. Jones, Kia Bariledum. **“Roman Catholic Church and Conflict Resolution in Nigeria, 1967 – 2000.”** *The Mangrove Journal of History and International Diplomacy*. Vol. 3, no. 1, 2026. 95-112.

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.63725/mjhid.v3i1.07>

Abstract: This article titled ‘Roman Catholic Church and Conflict Resolution in Nigeria’ examines the role of the Roman Catholic Church in conflict resolution and peacebuilding in Nigeria from the Nigerian Civil War (1967–1970) to the Boko Haram insurgency up to 2015. Drawing exclusively on secondary sources, the study explores the conceptual and theoretical foundations of faith-based conflict intervention and evaluates the Church's contributions to humanitarian relief, mediation, reconciliation and interfaith dialogue in a conflict-prone society.

The analysis is anchored on Conflict Transformation Theory and the principles of Roman Catholic Social Teaching, which emphasize justice, human dignity and the peaceful transformation of social relationships. The study finds that the Roman Catholic Church has been one of Nigeria's most influential non-state actors in conflict intervention. During the Nigerian Civil War, Catholic agencies coordinated extensive humanitarian operations while also supporting peace initiatives. Subsequently, the Church played significant roles in responding to the Maitatsine disturbances, ethno-religious conflicts in Kaduna and Jos, the Niger Delta crisis, electoral violence and the Boko Haram insurgency through institutions such as the Catholic Bishops' Conference of Nigeria, Caritas Nigeria and the Justice, Development and Peace Commission.

The study further reveals that the effectiveness of these interventions has been constrained by political interference, insecurity, religious polarization, and persistent suspicions regarding the Church's neutrality. By synthesizing the historical evolution, mechanisms and limitations of Catholic peace interventions across major conflicts, the study contributes to the growing scholarship on faith-based peacebuilding in Nigeria and demonstrates the strategic value of religious institutions as complementary actors in national conflict management. It recommends stronger institutional collaboration between government, faith-based organizations, and civil society to enhance preventive diplomacy, humanitarian response, and sustainable peacebuilding. The study concludes that while religious institutions cannot substitute for the state, the Roman Catholic Church remains an indispensable partner in promoting sustainable peace, social justice and national integration in Nigeria.

Uroko, Favour. C. **“Understanding the Reasons for the Unity of Roman Catholics in Nigeria in the Midst of Rising Pentecostalism”.** *Studia Historiae Ecclesiasticae* Vol. 52, no. 1, 2026.

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.25159/2412-4265/20704>

Abstract: This study examines the reasons why Roman Catholic congregants remain faithful to their mother church, notwithstanding the many attractions of

Pentecostal churches. The rising number of Pentecostal churches is something that should have given the Roman Catholic Church something to worry about. Rather, Pentecostalism has served as an environment where Roman Catholics go to find solutions to their problems – which may be physical or spiritual – and then return to their mother church. One begins to wonder what makes it so difficult for Roman Catholics to leave their church completely and become members of Pentecostal faith communities. Existing literature has failed to provide reasons for the unity of Roman Catholics in the midst of the proliferation of Pentecostal churches in Nigeria. Data was gathered from periodicals, gazettes, Roman Catholic archives, and relevant academic literature. Documentary analysis was adopted. The findings showed that Roman Catholics see the Roman Catholic Church as the first church, their family church, a church less exposed to exploitative tendencies through prophecies, and a church that synchronises African language and culture with its worship, among others. Notwithstanding that some Roman Catholics attend Pentecostal churches for one reason or another, including seeking solutions to their spiritual problems, most times they return to the Roman Catholic Church due to their perceived fulfilment.

Wycliff, Samuel. "Sowing in the Desert: The Establishment, Growth, and Challenges of Catholic Church in Katsina, Northwestern Nigeria, 1710–2023." *Veritas Journal of Humanities*, Vol. 6, No. 1, 2026.

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.66809/vjoh.2026.531dbd>

Abstract: Northern western Nigeria, which has been centre of Islamic scholarship since the 14th and 15th centuries owing to spread of Islamic religion through trans-Saharan trade, Arab merchants, and Islamic scholars' missionary activities, has over centuries experienced not only the spread of the religion of Christianity by different Christian missionaries' bodies but also the establishment and development of Churches, missionary schools, and healthcare centres by different Church denominations. In view of this, using primary and secondary sources, this paper examines the birth, growth, and challenges of the Catholic Church in Katsina since 1710, when the first attempt was made. The paper argues that the birth and growth of the Catholic Church were associated with colonial and post-colonial push-and-pull factors in migration and intergroup relations, the activities of Catholic missionaries, and the conversion of the Katsina Hausa and Fulani ethnic groups from traditional religion and Islam to Christianity. In fact, this gave birth to the growth of indigenous Hausa and Fulani Christians, the Catholic community, Catholic outstations, Parishes, Deaneries, and the Catholic Diocese of Katsina, which was created from the Catholic Diocese of Sokoto in the year 2023, with a native of Argungu, Kebbi State, Rt. Rev. Mssgr. Gerald Mamman Musa as its first bishop. This is a major landmark in the history of Northwestern Nigeria, where the heartland of Islam is, and also the seat of the Caliphate established by the Jihad of Uthman Danfodio since 1804, with a well-structured Islamic system of government.